

Chapter 1

A Way Can Be a Guide A way can be a guide, but not a fixed path; names can be given, but not permanent labels. Nonbeing is called the beginning of heaven and earth; being is called the mother of all things.	The principle that can be enunciated is not the one that always was. The being that can be named is not the one that was at all times. Before time there was an ineffable, unnameable being. When it was still unnameable, it conceived heaven and earth.	Words and names are not the way They can't define the absolute It's better that you look within Hold your tongue and just be mute Look within and look out too You will not find a		The Tao that can be told of is not the eternal Tao; The name that can be named is not the eternal name. The Nameless is the origin of Heaven and Earth; The Named is the mother of all things.
Always passionless, thereby observe the subtle; ever intent, thereby observe the apparent. These two come from the same source but differ in name; both are considered mysteries. The mystery of mysteries is the gateway of marvels. up	When it had thus become nameable, it gave birth to the multitude of beings. These two acts are but one, under two different denominations. The unique act of generation; that is the mystery of the beginning; the effects. up	separation Out there you see appearance Within you see origination Look within with wonder At emptiness and bliss For wonder names totality Where nothing is amiss The space within is always there If you can moderate desire A place of utter emptiness And possibility entire		Therefore let there always be non-being, so we may see their subtlety, And let there always be being, so we may see their outcome. The two are the same, But after they are produced, they have different names. They both may be called deep and profound. Deeper and more profound, The door to all subtleties! up

Chapter 2

Everyone Knows When everyone knows beauty is beauty, this is bad. When everyone knows good is good, this is not good. So being and nonbeing produce each other: difficulty and ease complement each other, long and short shape each other, high and low contrast with each other, voice and echoes conform to each other, before and after go along with each other.	Everyone has the idea of beauty, and from that by opposition that of not beautiful (ugly). All men have the idea of good, and from that by contrast that of not good (bad). Thus, being and nothingness, difficult and easy, long and short, high and low, sound and tone, before and after, are correlative ideas, one of which, in being known, reveals the other.	Where beautiful and ugly Do not stand in opposition Where life and death or yes and no Do not make a contradiction Can you see the vacant place Where good and bad and sad and merry Disappear forevermore?		
So sages manage effortless service and carry out unspoken guidance. All beings work, without exception: if they live without possessiveness, act without presumption, and do not dwell on success, then by this very nondwelling success will not leave. up	That being so, the Sage serves without acting and teaches without speaking. He lets all beings become, without thwarting them, he lets them live, without monopolizing them, and lets them act, without exploiting them. He does not attribute to himself the effects produced, and in consequence these effects last. up	Where nothing ever is contrary So stay within the emptiness Unless you rise you never fall Accepting that which comes your way You are forever all in all		Therefore the sage manages affairs without action And spreads doctrines without words. All things arise, and he does not turn away from them. He produces them but does not take possession of them. He acts but does not rely on his own ability. He accomplishes his task but does not claim credit for it. It is precisely because he does not claim credit that his accomplishment remains with him. up

Chapter 3

Not Exalting
Cleverness Not
exalting
cleverness causes
the people not to
contend. Not
putting high prices
on hard-to-get
goods causes the
people not to steal.
Not seeing
anything to want
causes the mind
not to be
confused.

Not making any
special case of
cleverness, of
ability, will have
the result that
people will no
longer push
themselves. Not to
prize rare objects
will have the result
that no one will
continue to steal.
To show nothing
as alluring will
have the effect of
putting the
people's hearts at
rest.

If you love
accumulation
Gain and
increase every
day Thieves and
robbers will be
waiting Just to
take it a

Stop looking for
rare, moral
persons (hsien) to
put in power.
There will be
jealousies among
people, jealousies
and strife. If we
cease to set store
by products that
are hard to get,
there will be less
outright thieves. If
the people never
see such things as
excite desire, their
hearts can remain
placid and
undisturbed.

Do not exalt the
worthy, so that the
people shall not
compete. Do not
value rare
treasures, so that
the people shall
not steal. Do not
display objects of
desire, so that the
people's hearts
shall not be
disturbed.

Therefore the
government of
sages empties the
mind and fills the
middle, weakens
the ambition and
strengthens the
bones, always
keeping the people
innocent and
passionless. it
makes the
sophisticated not
dare to contrive;
action being
without
contrivance,
nothing is
disordered. up

Therefore the
politics of Sages
consists in
emptying the
minds of men and
filling their
stomachs, in
weakening their
initiative and
strengthening their
bones. Their
constant care is to
hold the people in
ignorance and
apathy. They
make things such
that clever people
dare not to act, for
there is nothing
that cannot be
sorted out through
the practice of
non-action. up

Il away Best to
be so
empty-headed
That it seems
you've lost it all
You will know
you're on the
way Though
others say you're
at a stall

Therefore the wise
one rules by
emptying their
hearts [like the
clown]. He fills
their bellies,
weakens their
brightness and
toughens their
bones, ever
striving to make
the people without
knowledge. He
sees to it that if
there are any who
are bright and
clever, they dare
not interfere.
Through his
non-do actions all
[such subjection]
runs well [for some
time].

Therefore in the
government of the
sage, He keeps
their hearts
vacuous, Fills their
bellies, Weakens
their ambitions,
And strengthens
their bones, He
always causes his
people to be
without knowledge
(cunning) or
desire, And the
crafty to be afraid
to act. By acting
without action, all
things will be in
order. up

Chapter 4

The Way Is Unimpeded Harmony The Way is unimpeded harmony; its potential may never be fully exploited. It is as deep as the source of all things: it blunts the edges, resolves the complications, harmonizes the light, assimilates to the world.

The Principle produces in abundance, but without filling itself up. Empty abyss, it seems to be (is) the ancestor (origin) of all beings. It is peaceful, simple, modest, amiable.

This nothingness is like a well Always giving, never taking And all claims to origin Neither wanting o

Dao is like an empty vessel that yet can be drawn from without ever needing to be filled. It's without bottom; the very breeder of all things in the world. In it all sharpness is blunted, all tangles untied, all glare tempered, all turmoil smoothed.

Tao is empty (like a bowl). It may be used but its capacity is never exhausted It is bottomless, perhaps the ancestor of all things. It blunts its sharpness. It unties its tangles.

Profoundly still, it seems to be there: I don't know whose child it is, before the creation of images. up

Spilling itself out in waves, it seems to remain (it remains) always the same. I do not know of whom it is the son (where it comes from). It seems to have been (it was) before the Sovereign. up

r forsaking You know it's ever present You find it where you have no face It is a wondrous blessing Original amazing grace

It's like a deep pool that never dries. Was it too the child of something else? We can hardly tell. A substanceless image of all things seemed to exist before the progenitor that we hardly know of.

It softens its light. It becomes one with the dusty world. Deep and still, it appears to exist forever. I do not know whose son it is. It seems to have existed before the Lord. up

Chapter 5

Heaven and Earth Heaven and earth are not humane; they regard all beings as straw dogs. Sages are not humane; they see all people as straw dogs.		This emptiness is truly void And infinitely capacious It holds whatever comes its way Eternally tenacious Can you take whatever comes?	The universe seems without mercy, quite ruthless; in that wider perspective all things are but as ritual straw dogs. The wise man too is hard as nail; to him the people are but as straw dogs to throw.	Heaven and Earth are not humane. They regard all things as straw dogs. The sage is not humane. He regards all people as straw dogs. How Heaven and Earth are like a bellows.
The space between heaven and earth is like bellows and pipes, empty yet inexhaustible, producing more with movement. The talkative reach their wits' end again and again; that is not as good as keeping centered. up	This is all that we can understand of the Principle and of its action as producer. To seek to detail it further using words and numbers would be a waste of time. Let us hold ourselves to this grand idea. up	Though judgment calls it bad and good Seeing is acceptance And nothing to be understood	Yet heaven and earth and all that lies between is like a bellows; empty, yet yielding a supply that hardly fails. Work it, and more comes out. Whereas the force of words is soon spent. It seems far better to keep what's in the heart. So hold to the heart core and a regular mean.	While vacuous, it is never exhausted. When active, it produces even more. Much talk will of course come to a dead end. It is better to keep to the centre. up

Chapter 6

The Valley Spirit
The valley spirit
not dying is
called the
mysterious
female. The
opening of the
mysterious
female is called
the root of
heaven and
earth.

The expansive
transcendent
power which
resides in the
median space,
the virtue of the
Principle, does
not die. It is
always the same
and acts the
same, without
diminution or
cessation.

Complete and
full awareness Is
like an open
valley Of endless
generation That
doesn't rea

The valley spirit
never dies. It's
named the
mystic woman.
And the gate of
the profound
woman is the
root that heaven
and earth sprang
from.

The spirit of the
valley never dies.
It is called the
subtle and
profound female.
The gate of the
subtle and
profound female
Is the root of
Heaven and
Earth.

Continuous, on
the brink of
existence, to put
it into practice,
don't try to force
it. up

This virtue is the
mysterious
mother of all
beings. The
doorway of this
mysterious
mother is the
root of heaven
and earth, the
Principle.
Sprouting forth,
she does not
expend herself;
acting, she does
not tire herself.
up

ch finale It is a
simple presence
It's a nothing you
can see You'll
find it right at
center Wherever
you may be

It's there within
us all the while;
draw upon it as
you will, you can
never wear it out.

It is continuous,
and seems to be
always existing.
Use it and you
will never wear it
out. up

Chapter 7

Heaven Is Eternal, Earth Is Everlasting
Heaven is eternal, earth is everlasting. The reason they can be eternal and everlasting is that they do not foster themselves; that is why they can live forever.

If heaven and earth last forever, it is because they do not live for themselves.

This presence is unlimited Because it wasn't ever born And it will not be perishing Will never give you cause to mourn It truly wants for nothing It has no wishes of its own It i

Heaven is always, the earth, too. How can it be? Well, they don't live only for themselves; that's why they live long. So the wise man puts himself last, and finds himself in the foremost place, puts himself in the background; yet always comes to the fore.

Heaven is eternal and Earth everlasting. They can be eternal and everlasting because they do not exist for themselves, And for this reason can exist forever. Therefore the sage places himself in the background but finds himself in the foreground.

For this reason sages put themselves last, and they were first; they excluded themselves, and they survived. Was it not by their very selflessness that they managed to fulfill themselves? up

Following this example, the Sage, in withdrawing, advances; in neglecting himself, he conserves himself. As he does not seek his own advantage, everything turns to his advantage. up

s the one and only Eternally alone It holds itself in vacancy With no desire to advance Remaining in simplicity It merely witnesses the dance The seer will remain behind And never yearns for leaving home Just living in the here and now Prefers to stay unknown

He keeps well fit; looks on his body almost as accidental, outer, something to be well taken care of; still it always there, and always remains. He remains in the open by it, too. He hardly strives for great personal ends; his main ends seem fulfilled.

He puts himself away, and yet he always remains. Is it not because he has no personal interests? This is the reason why his personal interests are fulfilled. up

Chapter 8

Higher Good Is like Water Higher good is like water: the good in water benefits all, and does so without contention. It rests where people dislike to be, so it is close to the Way.

Transcendent goodness is like water. Water likes to do good to all beings; it does not struggle for any definite form or position, but puts itself in the lowest places that no one wants. By this, it is the reflection of the Principle.

The seer flows like water Lying low along the way Nourishing whatever comes To be held on display The seer keeps to simple ways

The highest good is like that of water. The goodness of water is that it benefits the ten thousand creatures; yet itself hardly ever scrambles - it seems quite content with the places that all men disdain. It's this that can make water so near to some dao.

The best (man) is like water. Water is good; it benefits all things and does not compete with them. It dwells in (lowly) places that all disdain. This is why it is so near to Tao. (The best man) in his dwelling loves the earth.

Where it dwells becomes good ground; profound is the good in its heart, benevolent the good it bestows. Goodness in words is trustworthiness, goodness in government is order; goodness in work is ability, goodness in action is timeliness. But only by noncontention is there nothing extreme. up

From its example, those who imitate the Principle, lower themselves, sink themselves. They are benevolent, sincere, regulated, efficacious, and they conform themselves to the times. They do not struggle for their own interest, but yield. Therefore they do not suffer and contradiction. up

And therefore is content When joy or sorrow manifests To give complete assent If you can clearly be yourself And never rise to interfere Everyone will cherish you And always hold you dear

In his heart, he loves what is profound. In his associations, he loves humanity. In his words, he loves faithfulness. In government, he loves order. In handling affairs, he loves competence. In his activities, he loves timeliness. It is because he does not compete that he is without reproach. up

Chapter 9

To Keep on
Filling To keep
on filling Is not as
good as
stopping.
Calculated
sharpness
cannot be kept
for long. Though
gold and jewels
fill their houses,
no one can keep
them.

To hold a vase
filled to the brim,
without spilling
anything, is
impossible; better
not to fill it so. To
keep an
over-sharpened
blade without its
edge becoming
blunt, is
impossible; better
not to sharpen it to
this extreme. To
keep a roomful of
precious stones,
without any of it
becoming
misappropriated, is
impossible; better
not to amass this
treasure.

Don't fill a bowl
Till it's more than
full Or sharpen a
blade Till it must
go dull Don't pile
up

Stretch a bow to
the full, and you'll
end up wishing
you'd stopped in
time; to hold and
fill to overflowing
isn't quite as able
as to stop in time.
Temper a
sword-edge to its
very sharpest, and
you'll find it soon
grows dull.

To hold and fill a
cup to
overflowing Is
not as good as to
stop in time.
Sharpen a sword
edge to its very
sharpest, And
the (edge) will
not last long.

When the rich
upper classes
are haughty,
their legacy
indicts them.
When one's work
is accomplished
honorably, to
retire is the Way
of heaven. up

No extreme can be
maintained for a
long time. Every
height is followed
by a decline.
Likewise for a
man.
Whomsoever,
having become
rich and powerful,
takes pride in
himself, prepares
thereby his own
ruin. To retire at
the height of one's
own merit and
fame, that is the
way of heaven. up

treasure That
comes at great
cost Approval
and riches Are
easily lost Can
you only do
What's really
needed Then
stop and
withdraw When
your task is
completed?

When gold and
jade fills your hall,
can it be well
guarded any
more? To be
proud with things
and glory given,
could bring ruin.
Wealth and place
breed insolence
and could slowly
harm and ruin: If
your work is done,
withdraw! That's
heaven's way. It
can be opposed to
lots of ways of
man.

When gold and
jade fill your hall,
You will not be
able to keep
them. To be
proud with
honour and
wealth Is to
cause one's own
downfall.
withdraw as soon
as your work is
done. Such is
Heaven's Way.
up

Chapter 10

Carrying Vitality and Consciousness Carrying vitality and consciousness, embracing them as one, can you keep them from parting? Concentrating energy, making it supple, can you be like an infant? Purifying hidden perception, can you make it flawless?	Keep your body and spermatic soul closely united, and ensure that they do not become separated. Apply yourself such that the air you breath in, converted into the aerial soul, animates this composite, and keeps it intact as in a new-born baby. Withhold yourself from considerations which are too profound, in order not to wear yourself out. As for love of the people and anxiety for the state, limit yourself to non-action.	Can you see as a child sees And keep the simple vision?		Can you keep the spirit and embrace the One without departing from them? Can you concentrate your vital force and achieve the highest degree of weakness like an infant? Can you clean and purify your profound insight so it will be spotless? Can you love the people and govern the state without knowledge (cunning)?
Loving the people, governing the nation, can you be uncontrived? As the gate of heaven opens and closes, can you be impassive? As understanding reaches everywhere, can you be innocent? Producing and developing, producing without possessing, doing without presuming, growing without domineering: this is called mysterious power. up	Let the gates of heaven open and close, without wishing to do something, without interfering. Know all, be informed on everything, and for all that remain indifferent, as if you knew nothing. Produce, breed, without taking any credit for what has been produced, without exacting a return for your actions, without imposing yourself on those you govern. There you have the formula for transcendent action. up	See the inner oneness With absolute precision Hold all things in your embrace The entire world is in your care Let things be just as they are Extend acceptance everywhere Let go all need to comprehend The truth is here where all behold Their infinite capacity To welcome and enfold		Can you play the role of the female in the opening and closing of the gates of Heaven? Can you understand all and penetrate all without taking any action? To produce things and to rear them, To produce, but not to take possession of them, To act, but not to rely on one's own ability, To lead them, but not to master them - This is called profound and secret virtue. up

Chapter 11

Thirty Spokes
Thirty spokes
join at the hub:
their use for the
cart is where
they are not.
When the
potter's wheel
makes a pot, the
use of the pot is
precisely where
there is nothing.

A wheel is made
of thirty
perceptible
spokes, but it
turns due to the
imperceptible
central axis of
the hub. Vessels
are made of
perceptible clay,
but it is their
imperceptible
hollow that is
useful.

The empty hub
at center Allows
a wheel to roll
The vacancy
within defines
The functio

We put thirty
spokes together
and call it a wheel;
but it's on the
space where
there's nothing
that the usefulness
of the wheel
depends. We turn
clay to make a
vessel; but it's on
the space where
there's nothing
that the usefulness
of the vessel
depends.

Thirty spokes are
united around
the hub to make
a wheel, But it is
on its non-being
that the utility of
the carriage
depends. Clay is
moulded to form
a utensil, But it is
on its non-being
that the utility of
the utensil
depends.

When you open
doors and
windows for a
room, it is where
there is nothing
that they are
useful to the
room. Therefore
being is for
benefit,
Nonbeing is for
usefulness. up

The
imperceptible
holes which
make the doors
and windows of a
house, are its
essentials. It is
the imperceptible
that produces
effects and
results. up

n of a bowl The
openness within
a house Provides
location to reside
The open space
that is my heart
Is where ten
thousand things
abide

We pierce and cut
out doors and
windows to make
a house; and it's
on these spaces
where there's
nothing that the
usefulness of the
house depends.
Take advantage of
what is, turn
existing into a
great advantage:
just make as much
as you can out of it
here. Feel free to
recognise the
possible
usefulness of
whats not yet here.
Prosper by clever
use of something
not yet.

Doors and
windows are cut
out to make a
room, But it is on
its non-being that
the utility of the
room depends.
Therefore turn
being into
advantage, and
turn non-being
into utility. up

Chapter 12

Colors Colors blind people's eyes, Sounds deafen their ears; flavors spoil people's palates, the chase and the hunt craze people's minds; goods hard to obtain make people's actions harmful.

Colours blind the eyes of man. Sound makes him deaf. Flavours exhaust his taste. Hunting and racing, by unchaining savage passions in him, madden his heart. The love of rare and difficult-to-obtain objects pushes him to efforts that harm him.

Too much sound can make you deaf Too many colors leave you blind Can you let desire die down And not leave emptiness behind?

The five colours tend to confuse the eye, the five sounds of music can deafen the ear, the five tastes all dull or spoil the palate. Excess of hunting and chasing makes a mind go mad. Things hard to get, keeps one on one's guard. Valuable things and products quite hard to get, can impede their owner's progress.

The five colours cause one's eyes to be blind. The five tones cause one's ears to be deaf. The five flavours cause one's palate to be spoiled. Racing and hunting cause one's mind to be mad.

Therefore sages work for the middle and not the eyes, leaving the latter and taking the former. up

Therefore the Sage looks to his stomach, and not his senses. renounces this, in order to embrace that. (He renounces what causes wear, in order to embrace what conserves). up

Wanting things can drive you mad And acquisition makes you poor See that you are everything And leave off wanting more

So the wise man is concerned with his tummy before his eyes. He can consider the tummy first, not the eye. That is: He disregards the world outside - "that", and he accepts, goes for and in the end grabs the supernatural powers dormant within - his daoist "this". Therefore he rejects the one but accepts the other.

Goods that are hard to get injure one's activities. For this reason the sage is concerned with the belly and not the eyes, Therefore he rejects the one but accepts the other. up

Chapter 13

Favor and Disgrace Favor and disgrace seem alarming; high status greatly afflicts your person. What are favor and disgrace? Favor is the lower: get it and you're surprised, lose it and you're startled. This means favor and disgrace are alarming. Why does high status greatly afflict your person? The reason we have a lot of trouble is that we have selves.	Favour, because it can be lost, is a source of worry. Greatness, because it can be ruined, is a source of fear. What do these two sentences mean? The first means that the care required to keep in favour, and the fear of losing it, fill the mind with worry. The second points out that ruin generally comes from caring too much for one's own greatness.	Fame and shame are equal And so are gain and loss It isn't very difficult To get this point across Having fame you know that you Are terrified to lose it Making gain you always fear That others will abuse it Can you see that you're not like Your image or reflection?		Be apprehensive when receiving favour or disgrace. Regard great trouble as seriously as you regard your body. What is meant by being apprehensive when receiving favour or disgrace? Favour is considered inferior. Be apprehensive when you receive them and also be apprehensive when you lose them. This is what is meant by being apprehensive when receiving favour or disgrace.
If we had no selves, what troubles would we have? Therefore those who embody nobility to act for the sake of the world seem to be able to draw the world to them, while those who embody love to act for the sake of the world seem to be worthy of the trust of the world. up	He who has no personal ambition does not have to fear ruin. He who is only concerned about the greatness of the empire (and not that of himself), he who only desires the good of the empire (and not his own good), to him the empire should be confided (and it would be in good hands). up	Just see you are totality By looking in your own direction The one who is not limited Accepts whatever comes or goes And cares for everything around On opening and close		What does it mean to regard great trouble as seriously as you regard your body? The reason why I have great trouble is that I have a body (and am attached to it). If I have no body, What trouble could I have? Therefore he who values the world as his body may be entrusted with the empire. He who loves the world as his body may be entrusted with the empire. up

Chapter 14

When You Look at It You Don't See It What you don't see when you look is called the unobtrusive. What you don't hear when you listen is called the rarefied. What you don't get when you grasp is called the subtle. These three cannot be completely fathomed, so they merge into one; above is not bright, below is not dark. Continuous, unnameable, it returns again to nothing.

Looking, one does not see it, for it is invisible. Listening, one does not hear it, for it is silent. Touching, one does not feel it, for it is impalpable. These three attributes must not be separated, for they designate one and the same being. This being, the Principle, is not light above and dark below, as are opaque material bodies. Like a slender thread, it unwinds itself (as continuous existence and action).

When you look, it isn't there Listen and you cannot hear it It seems to be beyond your reach Because you are so near it This single source of everything Appears to be an empty image Though it

Look at it, it can't be seen, is called the invisible. Listen to it, it can't be heard, is called the inaudible. Grasp at it, it can't be touched, is called the fine formless.. These three elude all solid inquiries And merge and become one. Its rising brings no light; its sinking, no darkness. Unceasing, continuous, it can't be defined, on the way back to where there's nothing.

We look at it and do not see it; Its name is The Invisible. We listen to it and do not hear it; Its name is The Inaudible. We touch it and do not find it; Its name is The Subtle (formless). These three cannot be further inquired into, And hence merge into one. Going up high, it is not bright, and coming down low, it is not dark.

This is called the stateless state, the image of no thing; this is called mental abstraction. When you face it you do not see its head, when you follow it you do not see its back. Hold the ancient Way so as to direct present existence: only when you can know the ancient can this be called the basic cycle of the Way. up

It has no name of its own. It goes back as far as the time when there were no other beings but itself. It has no parts; from in front one sees no head, from behind no rear. It is this primordial Principle that has ruled, and rules, all beings right up to the present. Everything that has been, or is, since the ancient origin, is from the unwinding of the Principle. up

cannot be understood You can see its naked visage Follow it to nothingness Approach it where you have no face From nowhere to infinity This vacant image leaves no trace From never to eternity This naked face is what you are An empty, vacant, open door Forevermore ajar

It's called shape free from shapes; forms without form; the image of nothingness. That's why it's called the elusive; Go towards them, and you can see no physical front; go after them, and you see no rear. Hold on to the dao of old to master the things of the present. Master what once was, at the start, It's the essence of rarefied, pearl-stringed dao.

Chapter 15

Skilled Warriors of Old Skilled warriors of old were subtle, mysteriously powerful, so deep they were unknowable. just because they are unknowable, I will try to describe them. Their wariness was as that of one crossing a river in winter, their caution was as that of one in fear of all around; their gravity was as that of a guest, their relaxation was as that of ice at the melting point.		Those of old who knew the way To origin and source within Have seen the place where wholeness And infinity begin Alert as one on a frozen stream Or one who watches for the foe Deferential as a guest And generous as melting snow Plain as an uncarved block of wood Expansive as a vale Transparent just like water Whose clarity will never fail Can you keep yourself so still That muddy water clears?		Of old those who were the best rulers were subtly mysterious and profoundly penetrating; Too deep to comprehend. And because they cannot be comprehended, I can only describe them arbitrarily: Cautious, like crossing a frozen stream in the winter, Being at a loss, like one fearing danger on all sides, Reserved, like one visiting, Supple and pliant, like ice about to melt.
Simple as uncarved wood, open as the valleys, they were inscrutable as murky water. Who can, in turbidity, use the gradual clarification of stillness? Who can, long at rest, use the gradual enlivening of movement? Those who preserve this Way do not want fullness. Just because of not wanting fullness, it is possible to use to the full and not make anew. up		And wait until right action Spontaneously appears?		

Chapter 16

Attain the Climax of Emptiness Attain the climax of emptiness, preserve the utmost quiet: as myriad things act in concert, I thereby observe the return. Things flourish, then each returns to its root. Returning to the root is called stillness: stillness is called return to Life, return to Life is called the constant; knowing the constant is called enlightenment.	He who has reached the maximum of emptiness (of indifference) will be firmly fixed in peace. Innumerable beings come out (from non-being), and I see them return there. They spring forth, then they all return to their root. To return to one's root, is to enter into the state of rest. From this rest they emerge for a new destiny, and so it goes on, continually, without end.	See that you are emptiness Always quiet and at peace You're in the place where all begins The space where all things cease All things arise and hav		Attain complete vacuity. Maintain steadfast quietude. All things come into being, And I see thereby their return. All things flourish, But each one returns to its root. This return to its root means tranquillity. It is called returning to its destiny. To return to destiny is called the eternal (Tao). To know the eternal is called enlightenment.
Acts at random, in ignorance of the constant, bode ill. Knowing the constant gives perspective; this perspective is impartial. Impartiality is the highest nobility; the highest nobility is divine, and the divine is the Way. This Way is everlasting, not endangered by physical death. up		e their day And then go back to the single source Returning to serenity With no regret and no remorse When you see the source within You only give assent You see you're everlasting And eternally omnificent		Not to know the eternal is to act blindly to result in disaster. He who knows the eternal is all-embracing. Being all-embracing, he is impartial. Being impartial, he is kingly (universal). Being kingly, he is one with Nature. Being one with Nature, he is in accord with Tao. Being in accord with Tao, he is everlasting And is free from danger throughout his lifetime. up

Chapter 17

Very Great Leaders Very great leaders in their domains are only known to exist. Those next best are beloved and praised. The lesser are feared and despised.

In the early days (when, in human affairs, everything still conformed to the action of the Principle), subjects scarcely knew that they had a prince (so discreet was the action of the latter). After this the people loved and flattered their prince (because of his good deeds), but later on, they feared him (because of his laws), and scorned him (because of his unjust acts).

It's best if you are barely known
The lesser state is being praised
Worse is being hated
Just stay empty

Of the best the people hardly ever know they exist; The next best they flock to and praise for nothing. The next they shrink from; the next get reviled. "Not believing people you turn them into liars" - such bosses don't command the people's faith.

The best (rulers) are those whose existence is (merely) known by the people. The next best are those who are loved and praised. The next are those who are feared. And the next are those who are despised.

Therefore when faith is insufficient and there is disbelief, it is from the high value placed on words. Works are accomplished, tasks are completed, and ordinary folk all say they are acting spontaneously. up

They became disloyal, though having been treated disloyally. They lost confidence in him though receiving only good words which were never put into effect. How delicate was the touch of ancient rulers. When everything prospered under their administration, the people believed they had done everything themselves, of their own free will. up

and amazed
Only do what must be done
And see you are the one alone
When you finish all will say We did this on our own

They lose faith in them and take to oaths! The wise man is a clever ruler; he values his words highly. It's so hard to get a single word from at any price that when his task is finished, a work well done, everyone says, "It happened by itself, and we did it."

It is only when one does not have enough faith in others that others will have no faith in him. (The great rulers) value their words highly. They accomplish their task; they complete their work. Nevertheless their people say that they simply follow Nature. up

Chapter 18

When the Great Way Is Deserted When the Great Way is deserted, then there is humanitarian duty. When intelligence comes forth, there is great fabrication.	When action conforming to the Principle dwindles, (when men cease to act with spontaneous goodness and fairness), artificial principles of goodness and fairness, prudence and wisdom (are invented). These artificial principles soon degenerate into politics.	Goodness and compliance Came when people l	When the great dao declined, jen and i arose, humanity and righteousness." Next, when brightness and know-how came in vogue, the great pretence fully started.	When the great Tao declined, The doctrine of humanity and righteousness arose. When knowledge and wisdom appeared, There emerged great hypocrisy.
When relations are discordant, then there is family love. When the national polity is benighted and confused, then there are loyal ministers. up	When parents no longer live in natural harmony, they try to make up for this deficit by inventing artificial principles of filial piety and paternal affection. When states had fallen into disarray, they invented the loyal minister stereotype. up	ost the way Spontaneity declined Hypocrisy was here to stay	When the six family relationships are not in harmony There's open talk of kind parents" dutiful sons" and deep love to children. A confused country enmeshed in disorder praises ministers in chaos and misrule.	When the six family relationships are not in harmony, There will be the advocacy of filial piety and deep love to children. When a country is in disorder, There will be the praise of loyal ministers. up

Chapter 19

Eliminate Sagacity, Abandon Knowledge Eliminate sagacity, abandon knowledge, and the people benefit a hundredfold. Eliminate humanitarianism, abandon duty, and the people return to familial love.

Reject (artificial, conventional, political) wisdom and prudence, (in order to return to primal natural uprightness). and the people will be a hundred times happier. Reject (artificial, conventional) goodness and fairness, (filial and fraternal piety), and the people will come back (for their well-being, to natural goodness and fairness), to spontaneous filial and paternal piety.

Banish learned discourse And everyone will be content Eliminate propriety Increase astonishment Stay away from fraud and swindle Everyone is bound to gain You really have it all you know There is no basis to complain Can you see your empty core?

Banish wisdom, discard knowledge, Then the people will benefit a hundred times. Banish human love, just dump righteous, moral justice, and then the people will be dutiful and recover deep love of their kin. Banish cunning and skill, dispel profit; dismiss utility," then thieves and robbers will disappear.

Abandon sageliness and discard wisdom; Then the people will benefit a hundredfold. Abandon humanity and discard righteousness; Then the people will return to filial piety and deep love.

Eliminate craft, abandon profit, and theft will no longer exist. These three become insufficient when used for embellishment causing there to be attachments. See the basic, embrace the unspoiled lessen selfishness, diminish desire. up

Reject art and gain, and evildoers will disappear. (With the primordial simplicity, they will return to primordial honesty). Renounce these three artificial categories, for the artificial is good-for-nothing. Be attached to simplicity and naturalness. Have few personal interests, and few desires. up

It isn't missing, gone or hidden Just let go of neediness And it will come unbidden

These three things are not enough; externals are somehow decorations, purpose's not enough; they tend to rob life and make it too little complicated. Therefore let people hold well on to keeping accessories; keeping simplicity to look at. Go on and shield their internal soul's nature as some ritual, raw block to hold, their private, secret means and foster less ardent desires.

Abandon skill and discard profit; Then there will be no thieves or robbers. However, these three things are ornaments (wen) and are not adequate. Therefore let people hold on to these: Manifest plainness, Embrace simplicity, Reduce selfishness, Have few desires. up

Chapter 20

You need not give
a yes or no Such
distinctions matter
little Keep your
vision open And
be at center
noncommittal See
that it's ridiculous
To seek success
and fear to fail To
ever want what
others want To
think you always
must prevail Other

people look so
bright I am dark
and void and null
Others are so very
sharp While I
alone am dull
Others are so
purposeful Only I
don't understand
Aimless, drifting,
weak and dumb
Uninteresting and
bland I see I'm
different from the
rest For I take in
what's plainly
shown And I take
my sustenance
Only from the
great unknown

Chapter 21

The Countenance of Great Virtue For the countenance of great virtue, only the Way is to be followed. As a thing, the Way is abstract and elusive: elusive and abstract, there are images in it; abstract and elusive, there is something there.	All of the beings which play a role, in the great manifestation of the cosmic theater, have come from the Principle, through its virtue (its unwinding). The Principle is indistinct and indeterminate, mysterious and obscure. In its indistinction and indetermination there are types, a multitude of beings. In its mystery and obscurity there is an essence which is reality.	Seeming utter emptiness Quite impossible to trace Yet it contains all images Within its wide embrace Appearing total darkness Yet you		The all-embracing quality of the great virtue follows alone from the Tao. The thing that is called Tao is eluding and vague. Vague and eluding, there is in it the form. Eluding and vague, in it are things. Deep and obscure, in it is the essence.
Recondite, hidden, it has vitality therein: that vitality is very real; it has truth therein. From ancient times to now, its name is the undeparting; thereby are seen all beauties. How do I know all beauties are thus? By this. up	From ancient times until the present, its name (its being) has stayed the same, all beings have come from it. How do I know that it was the origin of all beings? ... (By objective observation of the universe, which reveals that contingencies must have come from the absolute). up	see that it is right To stay with its obscurity The only origin of light This ever present openness At center and within Can be seen just anytime So look and look again	The life-force is real and to be trusted. It's true, and can be set to operate. and latent in it are evidences. From the days of old till now its chunks havent departed or ceased, By its chunks we can view some origin of all descended units. How do I know a father of a thing? How to know how some origin of a manifestation is formed? By much developed intuition, possibly.	The essence is very real; in it are evidences. From the time of old until now, its name (manifestations) ever remains. By which we may see the beginning of all things. How do I know that the beginning of all things are so? Through this (Tao). up

Chapter 22

Be Tactful and You Remain Whole Be tactful and you remain whole; bend and you remain straight. The hollow is filled, the old is renewed. Economy is gain, excess is confusion. Therefore sages embrace unity as a model for the world. Not seeing themselves, they are therefore clear. Not asserting themselves, they are therefore outstanding.		Overcome by giving up See that you are really nil Look into your emptiness If you want to have your fill Be satisfied with little Just content with what you need If you are always wanting more You surely are consumed by greed Abide in		To yield is to be preserved whole. To be bent is to become straight. To be empty is to be full. To be worn out is to be renewed. To have little is to possess. To have plenty is to be perplexed. Therefore the sage embraces the One And becomes the model of the world. He does not justify himself; therefore he becomes prominent.
Not congratulating themselves, they are therefore meritorious. Not taking pride in themselves, they last long. It is just because they do not contend that no one in the world can contend with them. Is it empty talk, the old saying that tact keeps you whole? When truthfulness is complete, it still resorts to this. up	One finds merit in him, because he does not brag. He increases constantly because he does not push himself. As he does not oppose himself to anyone, no one is opposed to him. The axioms from the old days cited above, are they not full of sense? Yes, towards him who is perfect, (who does nothing to attract to himself), all run spontaneously. up	your simplicity Though you are not on display See all things are shining bright In marvelous array If you do not boast or brag Everyone will hold you high If you do not argue You will prevail thereby Only see you are complete And all things have come to you Overcome by giving up All except your inner view	He doesn't define himself, therefore he is distinct. He doesn't boast, therefore people give him credit: he succeeds by that. He's never outright proud of his work, and therefore it endures. Because he doesn't contend, none in the world can contend with him. So the old saying To remain whole, seem twisted!" was no idle word; for true wholeness can only be won by return to dao.	He does not boast of himself; therefore he is given credit. He does not brag; therefore he can endure for long. It is precisely because he does not compete that the world cannot compete with him. Is the ancient saying, "To yield is to be preserved whole," empty words? Truly he will be preserved and (prominence and credit) will come to him. up

Chapter 23

To Speak Rarely Is Natural To speak rarely is natural. That is why a gusty wind doesn't last the morning, a downpour of rain doesn't last the day. Who does this? Heaven and earth. If even heaven and earth cannot go on forever, how much less can human beings!	To talk little, to act only without effort, that is the formula. A gusty wind does not blow all morning, torrential rain does not last all day. And yet these effects are produced by heaven and earth, (the most powerful agents of all. But these are exaggerated, forced effects, that is why they cannot be sustained). If heaven and earth cannot sustain a forced action, how much less is man able to do so?	Say your piece and then be still Like nature in a storm That rains and blows and ceases And sees the sun reborn Open to the inward view You are a		
Therefore those who follow the Way assimilate to the Way; the virtuous assimilate to virtue, those who have lost assimilate to loss. Those who assimilate to the Way are happy to gain it, those who assimilate to virtue too are happy to gain it, and those who assimilate to loss are also happy to gain it. When trust is insufficient, there is distrust. up		t one with all existence There's nothing blocking up the way Or putting up resistance If you're at home with nothingness And simply trust what comes about You'll find that all is in its place Without a question or a doubt		He who is identified with Tao - Tao is also happy to have him. He who is identified with virtue - virtue is also happy to have him. And he who is identified with the abandonment (of Tao) - the abandonment (of Tao) is also happy to abandon him. Those who lack trust will not be trusted. It is only when one does not have enough faith in others that others will have no faith in him. up

Chapter 24

Those on Tiptoe
Don't Stand Up
Those on tiptoe
don't stand up,
those who take
long strides don't
walk; those who
see themselves
are not
perceptive, those
who assert
themselves are
not illustrious;
those who glorify
themselves have
no merit, those
who are proud of
themselves do
not last.

By dint of holding
oneself on tiptoe,
one loses one's
balance. By trying
to take too great a
stride, one does
not go forward. By
making a show of
oneself, one loses
one's reputation.
Through imposing
oneself, one loses
one's influence.
Through boasting
about oneself, one
becomes
discredited.

Who stands on
tiptoe topples
Who runs ahead
soon loses
speed Who goes
on show is
hidden Who
push

Who stands on
tiptoe, doesn't
stand steady; He
who takes the
longest strides,
doesn't walk.." He
who does his own
looking sees little,
and he who shows
or reveals himself
is hardly luminous
He who justifies
and defines
himself isn't
subsequently
distinct. He who
boasts of what he
will do succeeds in
nothing; Who
brags doesn't
endure for long.
Who is proud of
his work, achieves
nothing well
lasting.

He who stands
on tiptoe is not
steady. He who
strides forward
does not go. He
who shows
himself is not
luminous. He
who justifies
himself is not
prominent. He
who boasts of
himself is not
given credit.

On the Way,
these are called
overconsumption
and excess
activity. Some
people disdain
them, so those
with the Way
abstain. up

Through pushing
oneself, one
ceases to be
augmented. In the
light of the
Principle all these
ways of acting are
odious, distasteful.
They are
superfluous
excesses. They
are like a pain in
the stomach, a
tumour in the
body. He who has
principles (in
conformity with the
Principle), does
not act like this. up

es far gives up
the lead Don't
depart from what
is given The ever
present here and
now Don't
overreach and
don't oppose
Invite, admire
and allow

Such people are
like remnants of
food and tumours
of action from the
dao point of view.
Good braggarts
could be dregs. So
it's said "Pass
round superfluous
dishes to those
that have already
had enough, Such
things of disgust
all are likely to
detest and reject in
disgust." So the
man of dao spurns
them. The man
that has dao
doesn't stay to
bray and show off.

He who brags
does not endure
for long. From
the point of view
of Tao, these are
like remnants of
food and
tumours of
action, Which all
creatures detest.
Therefore those
who possess
Tao turn away
from them. up

Chapter 25

Something
Undifferentiated
Something
undifferentiated
was born before
heaven and earth;
still and silent,
standing alone and
unchanging, going
through cycles
unending, able to
be mother to the
world. I do not
know its name; I
label it the Way.
Imposing on it a
name, I call it
Great.

Before creation
did occur This
blessed
emptiness was
here Alone
forever and at
peace The
source of all that
does appear
Eternally
unchanging
Forever lacking
limit This void is
all potential

There was
something
undifferentiated
and yet complete,
Which existed
before heaven and
earth. Soundless
and formless, it
depends on
nothing and does
not change. It
operates
everywhere and is
free from danger.
It may be
considered the
mother of the
universe. I do not
know its name; I
call it Tao. If forced
to give it a name, I
shall call it Great.

Greatness means
it goes; going
means reaching
afar; reaching afar
means return.
Therefore the Way
is great, heaven is
great, earth is
great, and kingship
is also great.
Among domains
are four greats, of
which kingship is
one. Humanity
emulates earth,
earth emulates
heaven, heaven
emulates the Way,
the Way emulates
Nature. up

The everlasting
ultimate It flows
through all
existence And
then returns to
source It's ever
at your center
Your only true
recourse For
here begins the
universe The
earth and
humankind
Following this
greatest way You
can never be
defined

Now being great
means functioning
everywhere.
Functioning
everywhere means
far-reaching. Being
far-reaching
means returning to
the original point.
Therefore Tao is
great Heaven is
great. Earth is
great. And the king
is also great. Man
models himself
after Earth. Earth
models itself after
Heaven. Heaven
models itself after
Tao. And Tao
models itself after
Nature. up

Chapter 26

Gravity Is the Root of Lightness Gravity is the root of lightness; calm is the master of excitement. Thereby do exemplary people travel all day without leaving their equipment.

The heavy is the base (root) of the light. Stillness is the prince of movement. (These things should be always united in a just temperament). Therefore a wise prince, when he travels (in his light carriage), never separates himself from the heavy wagons which carry his baggage.

The naked center doesn't change Its quietude is absolute Yet from it spring all things that move This bare awareness is the root Can you go about all day And never leave your true abode No matter how enticing are The splendors of the road?

The solid is the platform of the light, and the heavy is the root of the light. (Maybe firm integrity has to be the basis of light frivolity). Quiet strength rules over activity, the not-so-active could be the big boss of the hasty. So the wise man travels all day and never leaves his baggage; he who travels all day hardly likes to be separated from his provision-chart: However great and glorious the view, he sits quiet and dispassionate".

The heavy is the root of the light. The tranquil is the ruler of the hasty. Therefore the sage travels all day Without leaving his baggage. Even at the sight of magnificent scenes He remains leisurely and indifferent.

Though they have a look of prosperity, their resting place is transcendent. What can be done about heads of state who take the world lightly in their own selfinterest? Lack of gravity loses servants of state; instability loses heads of state. up

However beautiful the landscape through which he passes, he takes care to lodge only in peaceful places. Alas, how could an emperor behave so foolishly, losing all authority by dint of frivolity, and all the rest through his waywardness? up

Don't think that you can run around And act a perfect fool Just see that you are at the eye Of nature's whirlpool

How is it that a lord with ten thousand chariots Should behave lightheartedly in his empire? If he is lighthearted, the minister will be destroyed. If he is hasty, the ruler is lost. up

Chapter 27

Good Works Good works are trackless, good words are flawless, good planning isn't calculating. What is well closed has no bolt locking it, but cannot be opened. What is well bound has no rope confining it, but cannot be untied. Therefore sages always consider it good to save people, so that there are no wasted humans; they always consider it good to save beings, so that there are no wasted beings.

A good walker leaves no trace, a good speaker offends no one, a good reckoner needs no tally, an expert locksmith can make one that no one can open, an expert on knots can make them so that no one can untie them. (all specialists have their speciality, which makes their fame, from which they take their profit).

Can you walk and leave no tracks? Make no errors when you talk? Count without a tally? Secure a door without a lock?

A good traveller leaves no track or trace. A good speech leaves no flaws. A good reckoner uses no counters. A well-shut door needs no bolts, and yet it cannot be opened. A well-tied knot needs no rope and yet none can untie it. Therefore the sage is always good in saving men and consequently no man is rejected.

So good people are teachers of people who are not good. People who are not good are students of people who are good. Those who do not honor teachers or care for students are greatly deluded, even if knowledgeable. This is called an essential subtlety. up

You can abandon no one
There's nothing you can leave behind
In you there are no limits
You are forever unconfined
What happens is spontaneous
Good and bad are just the same
In origin identical
Beyond both praise and blame

He is always good in saving things and consequently nothing is rejected. This is called following the light (of Nature). Therefore the good man is the teacher of the bad, And the bad is the material from which the good may learn. He who does not value the teacher, Or greatly care for the material, Is greatly deluded although he may be learned. Such is the essential mystery. up

Chapter 28

Know the Male Know the Male Know the male, keep the female; be humble toward the world. Be humble to the world, and eternal power never leaves, returning again to innocence. Knowing the white, keep the black; be an exemplar for the world.		Know the strong but keep the weak The whole wide world is born in you You'll see just what a child sees A vast and comprehensive view Know the light but keep the dark And watch ten thousand things emerge In y		He who knows the male and keeps to the female Becomes the ravine of the world. Being the ravine of the world, He will never depart from eternal virtue, But returns to a state of infancy. He who knows the white and yet keeps to the black Becomes the model for the world. Being the model for the world, He will never deviate from eternal virtue, But returns to the state of the non-ultimate.
Be an exemplar for the world, and eternal power never goes awry, returning again to infinity. Knowing the glorious, keep the ignominious; be open to the world. Be open to the world, and eternal power suffices, returning again to simplicity. Simplicity is lost to make instruments, which sages employ as functionaries. Therefore the great fashioner does no splitting. up		ou they have their residence Where space and time converge Know the high but keep the low Humility will honor you Attend to your vacuity There's nothing else to do Be like an uncarved block of wood Don't squander your potential Or overlook your vacant core Nothing else is so essential		He who knows glory but keeps to humility Becomes the valley of the world, He will be proficient in eternal virtue, And returns to the state of simplicity (uncarved wood). When the uncarved wood is broken up, it is turned into concrete things. But when the sage uses it, he becomes the leading official. Therefore the great ruler does not cut up. up

Chapter 29

Should You Want Should you want to take the world, and contrive to do so, I see you won't manage to finish. The most sublime instrument in the world cannot be contrived.	He who holds the empire would, in my view, be wishing for failure should he want to manipulate it (to act positively, to govern actively). The empire is a mechanism of extreme delicacy. It should be let go all alone. It should not be touched. He who touches it, deranges it. He who wishes to appropriate it, loses it.		Those that would gain what's under heaven by tampering with it - I've seen that they don't succeed. For that which is under heaven is like a holy vessel, dangerous to tamper with. Those that tamper with it, harm it. Human go-between is likely to fail. Those that grab at it lose it. Who makes can spoil well; who holds can lose. Among creatures of this world some lead and some follow.	When one desires to take over the empire and act on it (interfere with it), I see that he will not succeed. The empire is a spiritual thing, and should not be acted on. He who acts on it harms it.
	When he governs, the Sage lets all people (and their sum, the empire) go free according to their several natures, the agile and the slow, the ardent and the apathetic, the strong and the weak, the long-lived and the short-lived. He limits his action to the suppression of excesses which would harm the whole, such as power, wealth, and ambition. up	Remain in pure awareness You never need to stray from home		He who holds on to it loses it. Among creatures some lead and some follow. Some blow hot and some blow cold. Some are strong and some are weak. Some may break and some may fall. Therefore the sage discards the extremes, the extravagant, and the excessive. up

Chapter 30

Assisting Human Leaders with the Way Those who assist human leaders with the Way do not coerce the world with weapons, for these things are apt to backfire. Brambles grow where an army has been; there are always bad years after a war.		There is an ancient way to lead That just allows and does not force For what goes out will come around And violence will lead to wars The one who sees comple		He who assists the ruler with Tao does not dominate the world with force. The use of force usually bring requital. Wherever armies are stationed, briars and thorns grow. Great wars are always followed by famines. A good (general) achieves his purpose and stops, But dares not seek to dominate the world. He achieves his purpose but does not brag about it.
Therefore the good are effective, that is all; they do not presume to grab power thereby: they are effective but not conceited, effective but not proud, effective but not arrogant. They are effective when they have to be, effective but not coercive. If you peak in strength, you then age; this, it is said, is unguided. The unguided soon come to an end. up		tes a task And stops when it is done Seeing all is on its own And not controlled by anyone The seer sees that all is well And does not need to please Just gives acceptance everywhere Puts everyone at ease		He achieves his purpose but does not boast about it. He achieves his purpose but is not proud of it. He achieves his purpose but only as an unavoidable step. He achieves his purpose but does not aim to dominate. (For) after things reach their prime, they begin to grow old, Which means being contrary to Tao. Whatever is contrary to Tao will soon perish. up

Chapter 31

		Weapons lead to violence Which everyone despises Avoid them altogether Allow no compromises If use of weapons has to be When enemies just leave no choice Use them but reluctantly In victory do not rejo		
--	--	---	--	--

Those who enjoy killing cannot get their will of the world. The left is favored for auspicious things, the right for things of ill omen: so the subordinate general is on the left, the top general on the right. That means when you are in ascendancy of power you handle it as you would a mourning. When you have killed many people, you weep for them in sorrow. When you win a war, you celebrate by mourning. up		ice Ascendancy brings sorrow And triumph doesn't carry pleasure It severs you from wholeness And robs you of your real treasure Victory is like a funeral Where loss of life must make you sad For putting other people down Never ought to make you glad		
--	--	---	--	--

Chapter 32

The Way Is Eternally Nameless The Way is eternally nameless. Though simplicity is small, the world cannot subordinate it. If lords and monarchs can keep to it, all beings will naturally resort to them. Heaven and earth combine, thus showering sweet dew.	The Principle has no name of its own. It is nature. This nature so unmanifest is stronger than anything. If princes and emperors were to conform themselves to it, all beings would collaborate with them spontaneously; heaven and earth would act in perfect harmony, sprinkling a sweet dew (the best possible omen); the people would be governable without the need for constraint.	Awareness is not limited It's like an uncarved block of wood With infinite potential Beyond all usefulness for good If leaders could stay centered In		Tao is eternal and has no name. Though its simplicity seems insignificant, none in the world can master it. If kings and barons would hold on to it, all things would submit to the spontaneously. Heaven and earth unite to drip sweet dew. Without the command of men, its drips evenly over all.
No humans command it; it is even by nature. Start fashioning, and there are names; once names also exist, you should know when to stop. By knowing when to stop, you are not endangered. The Way is to the world as rivers and oceans to valley streams. up	The Principle is, with reference to the diversity of beings in the world, like the mass of great rivers and oceans with reference to trickles and rivulets of water. up	awareness pure and plain This world would be as nourishing As nature's gentle rain Everyone would be at peace And always living in the whole Opposition and division Could never take their toll		As soon as there were regulations and institutions, there were names. As soon as there were names, know that it is time to stop. It is by knowing when to stop that one can be free from danger. Analogically, Tao in the world may be compared to rivers and streams running into the sea. up

Chapter 33

Those Who Know Others Those who know others are wise; those who know themselves are enlightened. Those who overcome others are powerful; those who overcome themselves are strong.	Knowing others is wisdom, but knowing oneself is superior wisdom, (one's own nature being most hidden and profound). Imposing one's will on others is strength; but imposing it on oneself is superior strength (one's own passions being the most difficult to subdue).	It may be said that you are wise To see yourself as others do But you are wiser still to see From y	He who knows others is learned; but he who knows himself is wise, nay, in the end it could be illumined. He who conquers others has strength of muscles; To conquer oneself is hard. So he who conquers himself is strong. To be content with what one has is to feel rich; so let the contented feel rich. Next: He who works, may eventually succeed. And he one who acts with vigour has will.	He who knows others is wise; He who knows himself is enlightened. He who conquers others has physical strength. He who conquers himself is strong. He who is contented is rich.
Those who are contented are rich; those who act strongly have will. Those who do not lose their place endure; those who die without perishing live long. up	Being satisfied (content with what destiny has given), is true wealth; being master of oneself (bending oneself to the dispositions of destiny) is true character. Staying in one's (natural) place (that which destiny has given), makes for a long life. After death, not ceasing to be, is true longevity, (which is the lot of those who have lived in conformity with nature and destiny). up	our own central point of view Then you see you have it all The riches that are always here Belong to you completely Because your vision is so clear		He who acts with vigour has will. He who does not lose his place (with Tao) will endure. He who dies but does not really perish enjoys long life. up

Chapter 34

The Great Way is Universal; The Great Way is universal it can apply to the left or the right. All beings depend on it for life, and it does not refuse. Its accomplishments fulfilled, it does not dwell on them. It lovingly nurtures all beings, but does not act as their ruler.

The great Principle extends itself in all directions. It lends itself willingly to the genesis of all beings (its participants). When a work is accomplished, it does not attribute it to itself. It nourishes all beings with kindness, without imposing itself on them as a master (for having nourished them; leaving them free; not exacting any degrading return from them).

The empty center's everywhere It flows both left and right It brings to pass ten thousand things And yet it never leaves your sight It welcomes everything around On noth

The Great Tao flows everywhere. It may go left or right. All things depend on it for life, and it does not turn away from them. It accomplishes its task, but does not claim credit for it. It clothes and feeds all things but does not claim to be master over them.

As it has no desire, it can be called small. As all beings take to it, yet it does not act as their ruler, it can be called great. Therefore sages never contrive greatness; that is why they can become so great. up

Because of its constant disinterestedness, one might think it would become diminished. This is not so. All beings to who it is so liberal, run towards it. It therefore finds itself magnified (through this universal trust). The Sage imitates this conduct. He, also, makes himself small (through his disinterestedness and his delicate reserve), and acquires thereby true greatness. up

ing does it make a claim It's in the heart of each and all This ultimate without a name Some can see that it is great And some will say that it's obscure It is your real identity Simplicity that will endure

Always without desires it may be called the Small. All things come to it and it does not master them; it may be called the Great. Therefore (the sage) never strives himself for the great, and thereby the great is achieved. up

Chapter 35

Holding the Great Image When holding the Great Image, the world goes on and on without harm, peaceful, even, tranquil. Where there is music and dining, passing travelers stop; but the issue of the Way is so plain as to be flavorless.	Because he resembles the great prototype (the Principle, through his disinterested devotion), all come to the Sage. He welcomes them all, does them good, and gives them rest, peace, and happiness. Music and good cheer may hold up a passer-by for but a night, (since sensual pleasures are fleeting and leave nothing behind).	Totality will be with you If you can see the simple presence Although there's danger all around You give complete acceptance Good music, food and company		Hold fast to the great form (Tao), And all the world will come. They come and will encounter no harm; But enjoy comfort, peace, and health. When there are music and dainties, Passing strangers will stay.
When you look at it, it is invisible; when you listen to it, it is inaudible; when you use it, it cannot be exhausted. up	Whereas the exposition of the great principle of disinterested devotion, simple and gentle, which charms neither the eyes nor the ears, pleases, engraves itself, and is of an inexhaustible fecundity in matters of practical application. up	Are welcome when you're traveling The inner truth seems tasteless Yet it produces everything You look and you see nothing You listen and hear silence Its use is inexhaustible It's ever worthy of reliance		But the words uttered by Tao, How insipid and tasteless! We look at it; it is imperceptible. We listen to it; it is inaudible. We use it; it is inexhaustible. up

Chapter 36

Should You Want to Contain Should you want to contain something, you must deliberately let it expand. Should you want to weaken something, you must deliberately let it grow strong. Should you want to eliminate something, you must deliberately allow it to flourish.

The beginning of contraction necessarily follows the maximum of expansion. Weakness follows strength, decadence follows prosperity, depravation follows opulence. This is a subtle insight (that many do not wish to see). All preceding strength and superiority is expiated by subsequent debility and inferiority. More calls for less, excess calls for deficit.

You cannot be diminished Unless you've been inflated You cannot be defeated Unless you've been elated You cannot be belittled Unless you've been esteemed

What's in the end to be shrunk can first be stretched. The one who is to be made to dwindle (in power) can first be caused to expand; and then it's necessary first to expand. Whatever is to be weakened must begin by being made strong [enough for it first of all]. He who is to be laid low can first be exalted to power. So: first promote, next destroy. Or: To destroy, first promote.

In order to contract, It is necessary first to expand. In order to weaken, It is necessary first to strengthen. In order to destroy, It is necessary first to promote. In order to grasp, It is necessary first to give.

Should you want to take something away, you must deliberately grant it. This is called subtle illumination. Flexibility and yielding overcome adamant coerciveness. Fish shouldn't be taken from the depths; the effective tools of the nation shouldn't be shown to others. up

A fish should not leave the depths (where it lives ignored but in security, in order to show itself at the surface where it could be harpooned). A state should not show its resources (if it does not wish the others to turn against it in order to crush it). up

Unless you're wholly missing You cannot be redeemed The soft and slow can overcome The rigid and the hard and fast Just see your inner emptiness For nothing else is made to last

This is called subtle light. The weak and the tender overcome the hard and the strong. Fish should not be taken away from water. And sharp weapons of state should not be displayed to the people. up

Chapter 37

The Way Is Always Uncontrived The Way is always uncontrived, yet there's nothing it doesn't do. If lords and monarchs could keep to it, all beings would evolve spontaneously.

The Principle is always non-acting (not acting actively), and yet it does everything (without seeming to participate). If the prince and the lords could govern like that (without poking their fingers in it), all beings would become spontaneously perfect (by returning to nature).

Only see you're doing nothing Yet not a thing is left undone For all things happen on their own In you who are the all in one If leaders c

Tao invariably takes no action, and yet there is nothing left undone. If kings and barons can keep it, all things will transform spontaneously. If, after transformation, they should desire to be active, I would restrain them with simplicity, which has no name.

When they have evolved and want to act, I would stabilize them with nameless simplicity. Even nameless simplicity would not be wanted. By not wanting, there is calm, and the world will straighten itself. up

It would only remain to call them back to unnamed nature (to the primordial simplicity of the Principle) each time they showed any tendency to come out of this state (by acting). In this state of unnamed nature there are no desires. When there are no desires all is peaceful, and the state is governed by itself. up

ould be centered All ten thousand things would thrive By seeing what is natural All creation comes alive Everyone would be content With living simply every day Desires would be moderate And peace would be the only way

Its an unnamed blankness; it could bring dispassion; As such nameless pristine simplicity is stripped of desire. So to be truly, artfully dispassionate, be free of desires and still. Simple wit and sense is free of desires. By stripping of desire true [yoga] rest is achieved almost of itself, the whole [body or] empire will be at rest of its own accord. And next the world [perhaps of somebody] could get at peace of its own accord.

Simplicity, which has no name, is free of desires, Being free of desires, it is tranquil. And the world will be at peace of its own accord. up

Chapter 38

Higher Virtue Is Not Ingratiating Higher virtue is not ingratiating; that is why it has virtue. Lower virtue does not forget about reward; that is why it is virtueless. Higher virtue is uncontrived, and there is no way to contrive it. Lower virtue is created, and there is a way to do it. Higher humanity is created, but there is no way to contrive it. Higher duty is done, and there is a way to do it.		You needn't search for power You already have it all To seek outside your empty core Is looking for a fall The seer doesn't do a thing But sees that all is finished Foolish people run about And leave totality diminished Goodne		
		ss must be doing And justice never is complete Propriety can't satisfy Obedience is forced defeat When totality is lost Goodness comes to take its place Followed by propriety Bewilderment and end of grace The seer sees periphery But also sees the open core And thus the seer sees the whole And dwells therein forevermore		

Chapter 39

Ancient Attainment of Unity When unity was attained of old, heaven became clear by attaining unity, earth became steady by attaining unity, spirit was quickened by attaining unity, valley streams were filled by attaining unity, all beings were born by attaining unity; and by attaining unity lords acted rightly for the sake of the world.		If you stay with clear awareness The sky is open, pure and spacious The earth is firm and friendly too Activity is efficacious But depart from clarity The purest sky is torn apart The		
		earth is so divided Felicity must flee your heart The seer knows humility Doesn't argue or cajole Doesn't discard anything Or mutilate the whole The seer doesn't show at all Doesn't sparkle like a jewel The seer's vast immensity Is truly less than minuscule		

Chapter 40

Return Is the Movement of the Way Return is the movement of the Way; yielding is the function of the Way.	Going back (towards the Principle) is the type of movement characteristic of those who conform themselves to the Principle. Attenuation is the result of their being conformed to the Principle.	All is born of emptiness Manifests and	Reversion is the action of dao. In dao the only motion is a return; and the one useful quality is named soft [or polite] gentleness, So polite or weak gentleness [or humility] is the function of dao.	Reversion is the action of Tao. Weakness is the function of Tao.
All things in the world are born of being; being is born of nonbeing. up	Considering all that exists is born of simple being, and that being is born of formless non-being, they tend, in diminishing themselves without cease, to go back to primordial simplicity. up	has its day Then yields and surrenders Returns and dies away Commentary	The creatures and things of this world come from being. And being from not-yet-being. though all	All things in the world come from being. And being comes from non-being. up

Chapter 41

When Superior People Hear of the Way When superior people hear of the Way, They carry it out with diligence. When middling people hear of the Way, it sometimes seems to be there, sometimes not. When lesser people hear of the Way, they ridicule it greatly. If they didn't laugh at it, it wouldn't be the Way.		When seers see their nothingness They never let it out of sight But others see it now and then And miss out on its true delight Still others only laugh it off And look at it with ridicule It wouldn't be the real truth If it weren't laughed at by		When the highest type of men hear Tao, The diligently practice it. When the average type of men hear Tao, They half believe in it. When the lowest type of men hear Tao, They laugh heartily at it. If they did not laugh at it, it would not be Tao. Therefore there is the established saying: The Tao which is bright appears to be dark. The Tao which goes forward appears to fall backward. The Tao which is level appears uneven.
		the fool The brightest way seems darkness Just going on seems like retreat The simple way seems difficult Capacity seems like defeat Clarity can seem obscure And love seem not to care Totality seems not enough And truth can seem to err Awareness doesn't have a name To all appearances is null Yet it produces everything And so this empty place is full		

Chapter 42

The Way Produces One The Way produces one; one produces two, two produce three, three produce all beings: all beings bear yin and embrace yang, with a mellowing energy for harmony. The things people dislike are only to be alone, lacking, and unworthy; yet these are what monarchs call themselves.	When the Principle has emitted its virtue, the latter begins to evolve according to two alternating modalities. This evolution produces (or condenses) the median air (tenuous matter). From tenuous matter, under the influence of the two modalities yin and yang, all sentient beings are produced.	Awareness comes from nothingness So all can see it's plainly one Contains all opposition Ten thousand things are now begun All these things embrace the void And face the manifest Achieving thus true harmony They		Tao produced the One. The One produced the two. The two produced the three. And the three produced the ten thousand things. The ten thousand things carry the yin and embrace the yang, and through the blending of the material force they achieve harmony.
Therefore people may gain from loss, and may lose from gain. What others teach, I also teach. The strong cannot master their death: I take this to be the father of teachings. up		find existence truly blessed No one wants to be considered Empty and alone Yet that's exactly what the seers Say they have been shown And violence is not the way I give you this instruction Those who live by violence Will bring about their own destruction		People hate to be children without parents, lonely people without spouses, or men without food to eat, And yet kings and lords call themselves by these names. Therefore it is often the case that things gain by losing and lose by gaining. What others have taught, I teach also: "Violent and fierce people do not die a natural death." I shall make this the father of my teaching. up

Chapter 43

What Is Softest in the World What is softest in the world drives what is hardest in the world.	Always and everywhere it is the soft that wears the hard (as water wears stone). Non-being penetrates even where there are no cracks (as in the most homogeneous bodies such as metal and stone).	Overcome by yielding The weak can overcome the strong For only absence can provide The place where everyth	The softest things in the world overcome the hardest things in the world. The softest substance radiates through the hardest. Also, what's most yielding can eventually overwhelm the hardest. Formless penetrates no-crevice; substanceless it can enter where there's no space; all this could be not-yet-being entering and jostling non-space. That's how I know the value of action that's actionless.	The softest things in the world overcome the hardest things in the world. Non-being penetrates that in which there is no space.
Nonbeing enters where there is no room; that is how we know noncontrivance enhances. Unspoken guidance and uncontrived enhancement are reached by few in the world. up	From that I conclude the supreme effectiveness of non-action. Silence and inaction - few men come to understand their effectiveness. up	ing belongs And thus it is that I can see The worthiness of not contending Yet few will ever comprehend The potency of bending	Through this I [also] know the benefit or advantage of taking no action. There can be [sad] teaching without words. To teach without words can be best. Still few can understand such stuff. And there can be solid value in action that's actionless, or the advantage of taking no action. Yes, the [said] benefit of taking no action is without compare. Few can understand it.	Through this I know the advantage of taking no action. Few in the world can understand the teaching without words and the advantage of taking no action. up

Chapter 44

Name or Body Which is closer, your name or your body? Which is more, your body or your possessions? Which is more destructive, gain or loss? Extreme fondness means great expense, and abundant possessions mean much loss.	Is not the body more important that reputation? Is life not of more consideration that wealth? Is it wise to risk a great loss for a small advantage? He who is a great lover, wears out (his heart).	Which of these means more to you Integrity or reputation? Are gain and loss not equally Responsible for limitation?		Which does one love more, fame or one's own life? Which is more valuable, one's own life or wealth? Which is worse, gain or loss? Therefore he who has lavish desires will spend extravagantly.
If you know when you have enough, you will not be disgraced. If you know when to stop, you will not be endangered. It is possible thereby to live long. up	He who amasses great wealth, heads toward ruin (by theft or confiscation). Whereas he who is modest courts no disgrace; he who is moderate does not perish, but endures. up	Everything that you possess Is surely transitory Just be pleased with emptiness And witness inner bliss and glory You know that your are always safe If only you can be contented With awareness as capacity And with all that is presented		He who hoards will lose most heavily. He who is contented suffers no disgrace. He who knows when to stop is free from danger. Therefore he can long endure. up

Chapter 45

Great Completeness Seems Incomplete Great completeness seems incomplete; its use is never exhausted. Great fullness seems empty; its use is never ended.	Accomplished, beneath an imperfect exterior. Giving, (of himself) without becoming worn out. Filled up, without appearing to be so, And pouring out without being emptied. Very straight, beneath a bent air; most able, behind an awkward appearance; highly perspicacious, with an embarrassed exterior.	Wholeness seems like imperfection Yet its usefulness is sure Fullness seems quite empty But it is certain to endure True straightness can seem twisted True wisdom does not seem to know Great eloquence seems halting Great darkness seems to be aglow Can you see that emptiness Contains all oppositions?		What is most perfect seems to be incomplete; But its utility is unimpaired. What is most full seems to be empty; But its usefulness is inexhaustible. What is most straight seems to be crooked.
Great directness seems restrained, great skill seems inept, great eloquence seems inarticulate. Movement overcomes cold, stillness overcomes heat. Clear stillness is right for the world. up	This is the Sage. Movement beats the cold (warms one up), rest overcomes heat (refreshes). The withdrawn life of the Sage rectifies all the empire (strikes at the root of its depravation. up	Like hot and cold and fast and slow? All differences and all conditions?		The greatest skill seems to be clumsy. The greatest eloquence seems to stutter. Hasty movement overcomes cold, (But) tranquility overcomes heat. By being greatly tranquil, One is qualified to be the ruler of the world. up

Chapter 46

When the World Has the Way When the world has the Way, running horses are retired to till the fields. When the world lacks the Way, war-horses are bred in the countryside.	When the Principle reigns (in perfect peace), war horses work in the fields. When the Principle is forgotten, (war horses are the order of the day) And they are raised even in the suburbs of the towns.	When the absolute is cherished Horses graze on the open green When the absolute is lost Only st		When Tao prevails in the world, galloping horses are turned back to fertilize (the fields with the dung). When Tao does not prevail in the world, war horses thrive in the suburbs.
No crime is greater than approving of greed; no calamity is greater than discontent, no fault is greater than possessiveness. So the satisfaction of contentment is always enough. up	To give in to one's covetousness (And this includes the mania for waging war), is the worst of crimes. Not to know how to control oneself, is the worst of nasty things. The worst of faults is to want more, always. Those who know how to say 'enough is enough', are always content. up	eeds of war are seen No calamity exceeds desire And always wanting more Can you not see you have enough And live in plenitude galore?		There is no calamity greater than lavish desires. There is no greater guilt than discontentment. And there is no greater disaster than greed. He who is contented with contentment is always contented. up

Chapter 47

Without Even
Going out the
Door They know
the world without
even going out
the door. They
see the sky and
its pattern
without even
looking out the
window.

Without going
out by the door,
one can know
the whole world;
without looking
through the
window, one can
become aware of
the way of
heaven
(principles which
rule all things).

No need to go
outside a door
To see totality Or
look out of a
window For
seeing what will

One can know
whats happening
all over the world
without going out
of doors. One
can see the dao
of the big wide
beyond here
without looking
out of ones
windows, and
see all the ways
of that
beyond-here.

One may know
the world without
going out of
doors. One may
see the Way of
Heaven without
looking through
the windows.

The further out it
goes, the less
knowledge is;
therefore sages
know without
going, name
without seeing,
complete without
striving. up

- The further one
goes, the less
one learns. The
Sage gets there
without having
taken a step to
reach it. He
knows before
having seen,
through superior
principles. He
achieves, without
having acted,
through his
transcendent
action. up

always be Going
out you go astray
At home and
center all is one
The seer doesn't
have to do To
see that
everything is
done

Then, the further
one travels the
less one knows.
So the wise man
can [at times]
arrive without
going and know
without going
about; he can
understand much
without seeing -
or achieve much
without [visible]
action.

The further one
goes, the less
one knows.
Therefore the
sage knows
without going
about,
Understands
without seeing,
And
accomplishes
without any
action. up

Chapter 48

For Learning You Gain Daily For learning you gain daily; for the Way you lose daily. Losing and losing, thus you reach noncontrivance; be uncontrived, and nothing is not done.

By studying, every day one increases (useless and injurious particular notions, in one's memory); by concentrating on the Principle, they are diminished every day. Pushed to the limit, this diminution ends in non-action, (the consequence of the absence of particular ideas).

In going after learning Something's added every day For resting in the ultimate Everything must drop away Day by day do less and less Until nothingness

The student of knowledge goes into learning a little day by day; The student of dao reduces his assets by dwindling or losing a bit each day. Learning consists in adding daily to one's stock, and the practice of dao consists in loose dwindling day by day. It could be subtracting till one has reached inactivity. By steady reductions [of certain sorts] you reach certain sorts of laissez-faire.

The pursuit of learning is to increase day after day. The pursuit of Tao is to decrease day after day. It is to decrease and further decrease until one reaches the point of taking no action.

Taking the world is always done by not making anything of it. For when something is made of it, that is not enough to take the world. up

Now there is nothing that non-action (letting things go) cannot sort out. It is through non-action that one wins the empire. To act, in order to win it, results in failure. up

is seen All occurs quite on its own A doer need not intervene Allow all things to run their course If you want to be proficient Make a fuss and bother And existence will be insufficient

No action is undertaken, And yet nothing is left undone. An empire is often brought to order by having no activity. If one (likes to) undertake activity, he is not qualified to govern the empire. up

Chapter 49

Sages Have No Fixed Mind Sages have no fixed mind; they make the minds of the people their mind: they improve the good, and also improve those who are not good; that virtue is good.	The Sage has no definite will of his own, he accommodates himself to the will of the people. He treats the good and the bad equally well, which is the true practice of goodness. He trusts the sincere and insincere alike, which is the true practice of trust.	The seer doesn't own a thought For thoughts do not reside within Thoughts concern ten thousand things And that's the way it's always been The seer doesn't rush to judge And treats all people well Considers no one bad or good A		The sage has no fixed (personal) ideas. He regards the people's ideas as his own. I treat those who are good with goodness. And I also treat those who are not good with goodness. Thus goodness is attained. I am honest to those who are honest, And I am also honest to those who are not honest.
They make sure of the true, and they make sure of the untrue too; that virtue is sure. The relation of sages to the world is one of concern: they cloud their minds for the world; all people pour into their ears and eyes, and sages render them innocent. up	In this mixed-up world, the Sage is without any emotion, and has the same feelings for all. All men fix their eyes and ears on him. He treats them like children, (Daoism kindness, sightly disdainful). up	ttracts but never does repel The seer trusts things as they are And takes all people at their word Giving trust to everyone Knows faithfulness will be returned The seer turns your view around So you can never be beguiled And gives you back all that you lost The vision of a little child		Thus honesty is attained. The sage, in the government of his empire, has no subjective viewpoint. His mind forms a harmonious whole with that of his people. The all lend their eyes and ears, And he treats them all as infants. up

Chapter 50

From Life into Death Exiting life, we enter death. The followers of life are three out of ten, the followers of death are three out of ten; in the lives of the people, the dying grounds on which they are agitated are also three out of ten. What is the reason? Because of the seriousness with which they take life as life.

Men go forth into life, And return in death. Out of ten men, three prolong their life (through cleanliness), three hasten their death (through their excesses), three compromise their life by the attachment they have to it, (And only one stays alive until his term, because he is not attached to it).

Between the time when they are born And the time that they will die Three in ten will follow life Three others only will deny Three others are so casual They live as though they're passing through But one remains who clearly sees There's not a single thing to do Can you be like the one who sees The world emerging on its own?

Man comes in to life and goes out to death. Three out of ten are companions of life. Three out of ten are companions of death. And three out of ten in their lives lead from activity to death. And for what reason? Because of man's intensive striving after life.

It has been said that those who maintain life well do not meet rhinos or tigers on land and do not arm themselves in war. There is no way for rhinos to gore them; there is no way for tigers to claw them; there is no way for weapons to get at them. Why? Because they have no dying ground. up

He who is not attached to his life, does not turn aside to avoid an encounter with a rhinoceros or a tiger; he throws himself into the fray without armour or weapons; And he comes to no harm because he is proof against the rhinoceros horn, the tiger's claws, And weapons of combat. Why is this? ... Because, exteriorized through his indifference, death cannot take a hold on him. up

What's needed for each moment Arises from the great unknown This one doesn't have a fear Of weaponry or wild beast These enemies can't harm the one Whose separate self is long deceased

I have heard that one who is a good preserver of his life will not meet tigers or wild buffaloes, And in fighting will not try to escape from weapons of war. The wild buffalo cannot butt its horns against him, The tiger cannot fasten its claws in him, And weapons of war cannot thrust their blades into him. And for what reason? Because in him there is no room for death. up

Chapter 51

The Way Gives Birth The Way gives birth, virtue nurtures, things form, momentum completes. Therefore all beings honor the Way and value its Virtue. The honor of the Way and the value of Virtue are not granted by anyone, but are always naturally so.	The Principle gives life to beings, then its Virtue nourishes them, until the completion of their nature, until the perfection of their faculties. Therefore all beings venerate the Principle and its Virtue. No one has the eminence of the Principle and its Virtue conferred on them; they have it always, naturally.	Everything arises From this total emptiness Is nourished and completed And finds creation blessed All things arise from nothingness Are cared for by exis		Tao produces them. Virtue fosters them. Matter gives them physical form. The circumstances and tendencies complete them. Therefore the ten thousand things esteem Tao and honour virtue. Tao is esteemed and virtue is honoured without anyone's order! They always come spontaneously. Therefore the Tao produces them and virtue fosters them.
So the Way gives birth and nurtures, makes grow and develops, completes and matures, builds up and breaks down. It produces but does not possess; it acts without presumption, it fosters growth without ruling. This is called hidden Virtue. up	The Principle gives life; its Virtue gives growth, protects, perfects, matures, maintains, And covers (all beings). When they are born, it does not monopolize them; it lets them act freely, without exploiting them; it lets them grow, without tyrannizing them. This is the action of transcendent Virtue. up	tence Which freely gives what is required For bountiful subsistence Existence does not make a claim On what it has created It nourishes and serves and leads Is honored and appreciated		They rear them and develop them. They give them security and give them peace. They nurture them and protect them. (Tao) produces them but does not take possession of them. It acts, but does not rely on its own ability. It leads them but does not master them. This is called profound and secret virtue. up

Chapter 52

The World Has a Beginning The world has a beginning that is the mother of the world. Once you've found the mother, thereby you know the child. Once you know the child, you return to keep the mother, not perishing though the body die. Close your eyes, shut your doors, and you do not toil all your life.		All things emerge from nullity The only derivation Of everything that manifests The source of all creation Stay in touch with origin There's nothing that you need deny Seeing your totality You will not fear to		There was a beginning of the universe Which may be called the Mother of the Universe. He who has found the mother (Tao) And thereby understands her sons (things), And having understood the sons, Still keeps to its mother, Will be free from danger throughout his lifetime. Close the mouth. Shut the doors (of cunning and desires).
Open your eyes, carry out your affairs, and you are not saved all your life. Seeing the small is called clarity; keeping flexible is called strength. Using the shining radiance, you return again to the light, not leaving anything to harm yourself. This is called entering the eternal. up	Whereas, if he talks a lot and causes himself much worry, he will use up and shorten his life. Restricting one's considerations to small things, And one's cares to affairs of little importance, makes the mind clear and the body strong. Concentrating one's intellectual rays in one's intelligence, And not letting mental applications harm one's body, is to protect (the mind) And make for long (life). up	die Do not be in haste to speak And always guard the senses You will find your heart at peace And in the place where all commences See the subtle and the clear It is the empty source of light There is no danger in this place That is forever in plain sight		And to the end of life there will be (peace) without toil. Open the mouth. Meddle with affairs. And to the end of life there will be no salvation. Seeing what is small is called enlightenment. Keeping to weakness is called strength. Use the light. Revert to enlightenment. And thereby avoid danger to one's life - This is called practicing the eternal. up

Chapter 53

Causing One Flashes Causing one flashes of knowledge to travel the Great Way, only its application demands care. The Great Way is quite even, yet people prefer byways.	He who has little wisdom, should conform himself to the great Principle. He should take care to avoid any irksome boasting. But to this wide road many prefer the narrow sidetracks. (Few men walk along the way of obscure disinterestedness. They prefer the narrow tracks of their vanity, their own advantage. This is how the princes of these times act).	This way is wide and easy Yet people love to stray They love to take the sidetracks And wander from the way When the few are rich and wealthy Living way above their needs The granaries are e		If I had but little knowledge I should, in walking on a broad way, Fear getting off the road. Broad ways are extremely even, But people are fond of bypaths. The courts are exceedingly splendid, While the fields are exceedingly weedy, And the granaries are exceedingly empty.
When courts are extremely fastidious, the fields are seriously neglected, and the granaries are very empty; they wear colorful clothing and carry sharp swords, eat and drink to their fill and possess more than enough. This is called the vanity of thieves; it is not the Way. up		mpty And the fields are full of weeds When rulers spend on weapons And implements of war It's a never ending circle Of ever wanting more When the rich have all abundance What remains must surely dwindle Having more than you can use Is thievery and fraud and swindle		Elegant clothes are worn, Sharp weapons are carried, Food and drinks are enjoyed beyond limit, And wealth and treasures are accumulated in excess. This is robbery and extravagance. This is indeed not Tao (the Way). up

Chapter 54

Good Construction Does Not Fall Down Good construction does not fall down, a good embrace does not let go; their heirs honor them unceasingly. Cultivate it in yourself, and that virtue is real; cultivate it in the home, and that virtue is abundant; cultivate it in the locality, and that virtue lasts; cultivate it in the nation, and that virtue is rich; cultivate it in the world, and that virtue is universal.	He who builds on disinterestedness will not find his work destroyed. He who keeps himself disinterested will not lose what he has. His sons and his grandsons will make offerings to him without interruption (that is to say, they will succeed him and enjoy the fruit of his works).	Hold fast to this awareness Seeing that it is your root It will not ever slip away This ever present absolute It cannot be uprooted It's always held in veneration Discovered very close at hand In every generation Allow its presence in your life		
So observe yourself by yourself, observe the home by the home, observe the locality by the locality, observe the nation by the nation, observe the world by the world. How do I know the world is as it is? By this. up		Awareness real and profound Allow it in the family Its blessings will abound And if you care to share it With neighbor and with friend Its potency will multiply With benefits that never end You ask me how I know it's true It isn't something I mistook Well nothing is more obvious The only thing I do is look		

Chapter 55

The Richness of Subliminal Virtue The richness of subliminal virtue is comparable to an infant: poisonous creatures do not sting it, wild beasts do not claw it, predatory birds do not grab it. Its tendons are flexible, yet its grip is firm. Even while it knows not of the mating of male and female, its genitals get aroused; this is the epitome of vitality.	He who holds himself in perfect Virtue (without lust or anger) is like the new-born child whom the scorpion does not bite, the tiger does not devour, the vulture does not seize, whom all respect. A child's bones are weak, its tendons are feeble, but it grasps objects strongly (just as its soul and body are held together by force). He has not yet any notion of the act of generation, And, in consequence, keeps his seminal virtue intact.	One who sees full emptiness Is like a child just born With muscles weak and bones so soft Yet with a grip that's strong The newborn hasn't been fulfilled Its nature is pure vacancy Nullity and nothingness And		He who possesses virtue in abundance May be compared to an infant. Poisonous insects will not sting him. Fierce beasts will not seize him. Birds of prey will not strike him. His bones are weak, his sinews tender, but his grasp is firm. He does not yet know the union of male and female, But his organ is aroused, This means that his essence is at its height.
It can cry all day without choking or getting hoarse; this is the epitome of harmony. Knowing harmony is called constancy, knowing constancy is called clarity; enhancing life is called propitious, the mind mastering energy is called strong. When beings climax in power, they wane; this is called being unguided. The unguided die early. up	He cries softly all day long without becoming hoarse, so perfect is his peace. Peace makes for durability; he who understands this is enlightened. Whereas any violent excitement, above all lust and anger, wears one out. From this it follows that virility (which man abuses) is succeeded by decrepitude. Intense life is contrary to the Principle, And in consequence prematurely mortal. up	potent spontaneity It can scream and cry all day And yet it never does get hoarse It only does what naturally Emerges from the inner source To see this inner nature Is seeing in a way that's bold Into the only place there is That cannot possibly grow old		

Chapter 56

Those Who Know Do Not Say Those who know do not say; those who say do not know. Close the senses, shut the doors; blunt the sharpness, resolve the complications; harmonize the light, assimilate to the world.

He who knows (the Principle), does not speak. He keeps his mouth closed, controls his breathing, blunts his activity, rescues himself from any complication, tempers his light, And mingles with people. This is mysterious union (with the Principle).

Those who know don't like to say Those who say don't know Close the mouth and guard the senses You'll see more than what's on show Untie tangles, dim the

He who knows does not speak. He who speaks does not know. Close the mouth. Shut the doors. Blunt the sharpness. Untie the tangles. Soften the light. Become one with the dusty world. This is called the profound identification.

This is called mysterious sameness. It cannot be made familiar, yet cannot be estranged; it cannot be profited, yet cannot be harmed; it cannot be valued, yet cannot be demeaned. Therefore it is precious for the world. up

No one can attach himself (by doing favours) to such a man, nor repulse him (by treating him badly). He is indifferent to gain or loss, exaltation or humiliation. Being thus, he is the most noble in the world. up

glare Dull the sharp and join the dust Abide in primal unity And then do what you must You cannot hold it or let go It can't be blamed or praised In all-embracing oneness Be astonished and amazed

Certain forms of loss can hardly reach up to this. It can be hard to repel and shoo such an accomplished god-being, as it's impossible to be distant and indifferent to him. He can't be raised, can't be much humbled, and disgrace can hardly affect him deep inside. So he is already highest of all humbled creatures. He is to be so honoured by the world.

Therefore it is impossible either to be intimate and close to him or to be distant and indifferent to him. It is impossible either to benefit him or to harm him. It is impossible either to honour him or disgrace him. For this reason he is honoured by the world. up

Chapter 57

Govern Nations by Normalcy Use straightforwardness for civil government, use surprise for military operations; use noninvolvement to take the world. How do I know this? The more taboos there are in the world, the poorer the populace is; the more crafts the people have the more exotic things are produced; the more laws are promulgated, the greater the number of thieves.	One can govern with rectitude, one can wage war with competence, but it takes non-action to win and hold the empire. How do I know that this is so? From what I am going to say: The more rules there are, the less people enrich themselves. The more taxes there are, the less order there is.	To truly lead with fairness You must put aside control Abandon imposition Make spontaneity your goal The more you try to run their lives With rules and prohibition The poorer people's lives become The more they live in opposition The more you deal with others With cunning and with guile The more that		
Therefore the sage says, I contrive nothing, and the people are naturally civilized; I am fond of tranquility, and the people are naturally upright. I have nothing to do, and the people are naturally enriched; I have no desire, and the people are naturally simple. up		other people say Our lives are not worthwhile The more you hoard your treasures The more you're giving hope to thieves The more you sharpen weapons The more the country grieves Do nothing and see all is done And everyone is true Drop the rules and people owe Prosperity to you Just let go of all desire And people will return To natural and simple ways To life without concern		The more laws and orders are made prominent, The more thieves and robbers there will be. Therefore the sage says: I take no action and the people of themselves are transformed. I love tranquillity and the people of themselves become correct. I engage in no activity and the people of themselves become prosperous. I have no desires and the people of themselves become simple. up

Chapter 58

When the Government Is Unobtrusive When the government is unobtrusive, the people are pure. When the government is invasive, the people are wanting. Calamity is what fortune depends upon; fortune is what calamity subdues. Who knows how it will all end?	When the government is simple, the people abound in virtue. When the government is political, the people lack virtue. Good and bad succeed one another, alternately. Who will discern the heights? (of this circular movement, of good and evil. It is very delicate, an excess or a default changing the moral entity). In many the right measure is lacking.	Let your lead be gentle And people will be satisfied Let it be severe and harsh And be rejected and defied Happiness may reign today But who knows what tomorrow holds?		
Is there no right and wrong? The orthodox also becomes unorthodox, the good also becomes ill; people's confusion is indeed long-standing. Therefore sages are upright without causing injury, honest without hurting, direct but not tactless, illumined but not flashy. up	In some an exaggerated righteousness degenerates into a mania. In others an exaggerated goodness becomes extravagance. (Points of view changing in consequence. For a long time now, men have thus been crazy. The Sage takes them as they are). Taking them to task, he is not sharp or cutting. Straight, he is not rude. Enlightened, he does not humiliate. up	Sadness too will have its time As all ten thousand things unfold The seer's sight is sharp and pointed But it does not cut or pierce The seer sees and shows the truth This gentle way is never fierce		And the good again will become evil. The people have been deluded for a long time. Therefore the sage is as pointed as a square but does not pierce. He is as acute as a knife but does not cut. He is as straight as an unbent line but does not extend. He is as bright as light but does not dazzle. up

Chapter 59

To Govern the Human and Serve the Divine To govern the human and serve the divine, nothing compares to frugality. Only frugality brings early recovery; early recovery means buildup of power. Build up virtue, and you master all. When you master all, no one knows your limit.	The essential for co-operation with heaven in the government of men, is to moderate one's action. This moderation should be the prime care. It procures perfect efficacy, which succeeds in everything, even the governing of the empire.	To serve and care for others With restraint and moderation Stay centered in the here		To rule people and to serve Heaven there is nothing better than to be frugal. Only by being frugal can one recover quickly. To recover quickly means to accumulate virtue heavily. By the heavy accumulation of virtue one can overcome everything. If one can overcome everything, then he will acquire a capacity the limit of which is beyond anyone's knowledge.
When no one knows your limit, you can maintain a nation. When you maintain the matrix of a nation, you can last long. This is called making the root deep and the basis firm, the Way of long life and eternal vision. up	He who possesses this mother of the empire (wise moderation), will last a long time. It is called the pivoting root, the solid trunk. It is the principle of perpetuity. up	and now And free of limitation If you keep returning To this your central root You will possess forever Awareness undilute		When his capacity is beyond anyone's knowledge, he is fit to rule a state. He who possesses the Mother (Tao) of the state will last long. This means that the roots are deep and the stalks are firm, which is the way of long life and everlasting vision. up

Chapter 60

Governing a Large Nation Is like Cooking Small Fry
Governing a large nation is like cooking little fish. When the world is ruled by the Way, the ghosts are powerless.

To govern a great state, one should act like someone cooking a very small fish (very delicately, otherwise they break up). When a state is governed according to the Principle, phantoms do not appear there to harm the people, because the Sage who governs does not harm the people.

It's best to lead a large domain As you would cook a little fish Don't poke and prod or you are bound To spoil the country and the dish Just stay ope

Ruling a big country is like cooking a small fish. If Tao is employed to rule the empire, Spiritual beings will lose their supernatural power. Not that they lose their spiritual power, But their spiritual power can no longer harm people.

It is not that the ghosts are powerless; their spirits do not harm the people. Not only do the spirits not harm the people; sages do not harm the people either. Because the two do not harm each other, their virtues ultimately combine. up

Not that the spirits have no more powers, But their powers will not harm men./ Neither will they harm men, Nor will the Sage harm the people. The merit of this double tranquility (on the part of the living and the dead) comes back, therefore, to the Sage. up

n and aware And evil cannot get a hold Cannot find a home in you Even evil's not that bold At center you harm no one And no one's able to harm you This kind of reciprocity Creates the world anew

Not only will their supernatural power not harm people, But the sage also will not harm people. When both do not harm each other, Virtue will be accumulated in both for the benefit (of the people). up

Chapter 61

A Great Nation Flows Downward A great nation flows downward into intercourse with the world. The female of the world always prevails over the male by stillness. Because stillness is considered lower, by lowering itself to a small nation a great nation takes a small nation; by being lower than a great nation a small nation takes a great nation.	If a great state lowers itself, like those holes in which water accumulates, everyone will come to it. It will belike the universal female. In her apparent passivity and inferiority, the female is superior to the male (for it is she who gives birth).	A great domain is like the sea Whose power comes from lying low And due to this humility Its greatness has to grow A small do		A big country may be compared to the lower part of a river. It is the converging point of the world; It is the female of the world. The female always overcomes the male by tranquillity, And by tranquillity she is underneath. A big state can take over a small state if it places itself below the small state; And the small state can take over a big state if it places itself below the big state.
So one takes by lowering itself, another takes by being lower. A great nation wants no more than to include and nurture people; a small nation wants no more than to admit and serve people. Both get what they want, so the great should be below. up	On condition of knowing how to lower itself, a great state will win over lesser states, which in their turn, will lower themselves, seeking its protection. For this to be realized, only one thing is needed, but it is essential. It is that the great state deigns to lower itself before the lesser ones. (if it is proud and hard, there is no hope). up	main can lie low too Acknowledging its low location Surrender and humility Give rise to exaltation If you lie low you too arise To uppermost position For everyone's attracted to One who doesn't fear submission		Thus some, by placing themselves below, take over (others), And some, by being (naturally) low, take over (other states). After all, what a big state wants is but to annex and herd others, And what a small state wants is merely to join and serve others. Since both big and small states get what they want, The big state should place itself low. up

Chapter 62

The Way Is the Pivot of All Things The Way is the pivot of all things: the treasure of good people, the safeguard of those who are not good. Fine words can be sold, honored acts can oppress people; why should people who are not good abandon them?				Tao is the storehouse of all things. It is the good man's treasure and the bad man's refuge. Fine words can buy honour, And fine deeds can gain respect from others. Even if a man is bad, when has (Tao) rejected him?
Therefore to establish an emperor and set up high officials, one may have a great jewel and drive a team of horses, but that is not as good as advancing calmly on this Way. Why did the ancients value this Way? By it one can attain without long seeking and escape from the faults one has; therefore it is valued by the world. up	Not so that they should become complacent with their sceptre and their ancient four-horsed chariot; but in order that they should meditate on the Principle (advancing themselves in their knowledge, and in the development of others). Why did the ancients make so much of the Principle? is it not because it is the source of all good and the remedy for all evil? It is the most noble thing in the world. up	It does away with imperfection Those who seek are bound to find It disappears on close inspection		Therefore on the occasion of crowning an emperor or installing the three ministers, Rather than present four large pieces of jade preceded by teams of four horses, It is better to kneel and offer this Tao. Why did the ancients highly value this Tao? Did they not say, "Those who seek shall have it and those who sin shall be freed"? For this reason it is valued by the world. up

Chapter 63

Do Nondoing Do nondoing, strive for nonstriving, savor the flavorless, regard the small as important, make much of little, repay enmity with virtue; plan for difficulty when it is still easy, do the great while it is still small. The most difficult things in the world must be done while they are easy; the greatest things in the world must be done while they are small.	To act without acting; to be busy without being busy; to taste without tasting; to look equally on the great, the small, the many and the few; to be indifferent to thanks and reproaches; this is how the Sage acts. He only sets about difficult complications through their easiest details, and only applies himself to great problems in their weak beginnings.	Begin with the easy And do without doing There isn't a thing That you should be pursuing Begin with the simple There's no need attacking Your greatness will lie In all tha		Act without action. Do without ado. Taste without tasting. Whether it is big or small, many or few, repay hatred with virtue. Prepare for the difficult while it is still easy. Deal with the big while it is still small. Difficult undertakings have always started with what is easy.
Because of this sages never do great things; that is why they can fulfill their greatness. If you agree too easily, you'll be little trusted; if you take it easy a lot, you'll have a lot of problems. Therefore it is through difficulty that sages end up without problems. up	The Sage never undertakes anything great, and that is why he makes great things. He who promises much, cannot keep his word; he who embarrasses himself with too many things, even easy things, never succeeds in anything. The Sage keeps clear of difficulty, therefore he never has any difficulties. up	t you're lacking Tackle problems when they're small And still subject to solution The largest problem is resolved By simple deeds of diminution Can you center every day And see all the seers see Empty here and brimming there A marvelous asymmetry?		And great undertakings have always started with what is small. Therefore the sage never strives for the great, And thereby the great is achieved. He who makes rash promises surely lacks faith. He who takes things too easily will surely encounter much difficulty. For this reason even the sage regards things as difficult. And therefore he encounters no difficulty. up

Chapter 64

What is at rest is easy to hold. What is at rest is easy to hold. What has not shown up is easy to take into account. What is frail is easy to break. What is vague is easy to dispel. Do it before it exists; govern it before there's disorder. The most massive tree grows from a sprout; the highest building rises from a pile of earth; a journey of a thousand miles begins with a step.

To keep the peace is easy. Begin before a problem stirs. Handle things before they happen. And trouble before it occurs. Be calm and conquer worries. Before they can proceed. The very largest tree begins.

As just a tiny seed. It takes a single step to start. A journey of a thousand miles. And just one brick to start to build. The grandest domiciles. Let things happen as they will. You do not need to interfere. See that you do nothing. That causes discord to appear.

Chapter 65

Good Practitioners of the Way in Ancient Times In ancient times, good practitioners of the Way did not use it to enlighten the people, but to make them unsophisticated. When people are unruly, it is because of their sophistication. So to govern a country by cunning is to rob the country.	In antiquity, those who conformed themselves to the Principle did not seek to make the people clever, but aimed at keeping them simple. When people are difficult to govern, it is because they know too much.	Those of old who found the way Could see their inner core They saw that it was hidden And didn't bring it to the fore When people think they		In ancient times those who practiced Tao well Did not seek to enlighten people, but to make them ignorant. People are difficult to govern because they have too much knowledge. Therefore he who rules the state through knowledge is a robber of the state; He who rules a state not through knowledge is a blessing to the state.
Not using cunning to govern a country is good fortune for the country. To know these two is also a model. Being always aware of the model is called hidden virtue. Hidden virtue is deep, far-reaching, in contrast to ordinary people. Only when it is thus does it reach great accord. up	Those who claim to procure the good of a country by disseminating instruction, are wrong, and ruin the country. This is the formula of mysterious action, of great profundity, of great bearing. It is not to the taste of (the curious) but, thanks to it, everything turns out well, peacefully. up	know the truth They want all others to concur But they are happy and content When they remain unsure Don't try to lead with cleverness Prefer instead simplicity It's obvious that truth must lie In nothingness and clarity		One who knows these two things also (knows) the standard. Always to know the standard is called profound and secret virtue. Virtue becomes deep and far-reaching, And with it all things return to their original state. Then complete harmony will be reached. up

Chapter 66

Rivers and Seas Are Lords of the Hundred Valleys The reason why rivers and seas Can be lords of the hundred valleys is that they lower themselves to them well; therefore they can be lords of the hundred valleys. So when sages wish to rise above people, they lower themselves to them in their speech.	Why are the oceans and rivers kings of all the valleys? (receiving all the watercourses in tribute). Because they are benevolently the inferiors of all the valleys (with regard to levels). That is why all the water flows towards them. Following this example, the Sage who wishes to become superior to the common people should speak in words beneath himself (speak very humbly of himself).	The sea is large and mighty Because it lies below The streams and rivers of the world Thus capturing their flow If you want to have your fill Then you must see that you are hollow If you want to lead the way		The great rivers and seas are kings of all mountains streams Because they skillfully stay below them. That is why they can be their kings. Therefore, in order to be the superior of the people, One must, in the use of words, place himself below them.
When they want to precede people, they go after them in status. So when sages rule, people don't take it gravely. And when sages are in the forefront, people don't attack them. Therefore the world happily backs them and does not tire of them. Because they do not contend, no one in the world can contend with them. up	If he wishes to become the first, he should put himself in last place, (and continue to do so, after he has been exalted). He could then be elevated to the highest peak without the people feeling oppressed by him; he could be the first without the people complaining about him. The whole empire would serve him with joy, without becoming weary of him. For, not being opposed to anyone, no one would be opposed to him. up	Then you must be prepared to follow When you lead you are above But no one feels put down And when you must be out in front Know that no one's losing ground When you see that you're not built For facing up or confrontation No one can contend with you Who are the ultimate negation		And in order to be ahead of the people, One must, in one's own person, follow them. Therefore the sage rejoices in praising him without getting tired of it. It is precisely because he does not compete that the world cannot compete with him. up

Chapter 67

Everyone Says Everyone in the world says my Way is great, but it seems incomparable. It is just because it is great that it seems incomparable: when comparisons are long established it becomes trivialized. I have three treasures that I keep and hold: one is mercy, the second is frugality, the third is not presuming to be at the head of the world. By reason of mercy, one can be brave.		On seeing inner nothingness You see it's great beyond compare Though many find it curious That you would even care I have three treasures that I keep The first is friendliness The second is to stay behind The thi		All the world says that my Tao is great and does not seem to resemble (the ordinary). It is precisely because it is great that it does not resemble (the ordinary). If it did resemble, it would have been small for a long time. I have three treasures. Guard and keep them: The first is deep love, The second is frugality, And the third is not to dare to be ahead of the world. Because of deep love, one is courageous.
By reason of frugality, one can be broad. By not presuming to be at the head of the world, one can make your potential last. Now if one were bold but had no mercy, if one were broad but were not frugal, if one went ahead without deference, one would die. Use mercy in war, and you win; use it for defense, and you're secure. Those whom heaven is going to save are those it guards with mercy. up		rd is wanting less For if you're friendly and you care You can dare to do what's needed And if you always stay behind The lead will surely be conceded And if you're satisfied with less You have everything to give Keep these treasures in your heart Then you will truly live		

Chapter 68

Good Warriors
Good warriors do not arm, good fighters don't get mad, good winners don't contend, good employers serve their workers.

He who commands should not think that tactics, valour, and effort give victory. It is by putting oneself at the service of men that one subdues them. That is the correct procedure.

Violence is not the way The greatest warriors know That treachery and anger Will not def

A skilful leader of troops is never oppressive with his military strength. The brave soldier is hardly very violent; The best fighter doesn't become visibly angry; he hardly loses his temper. A skilful conqueror doesn't compete with people. The great conqueror doesn't fight for small issues alone.

A skillful leader of troops is not oppressive with his military strength. A skilful fighter does not become angry. A skilful conqueror does not compete with people.

This is called the virtue of noncontention; this is called mating with the supremely natural and pristine. up

It is sometimes formulated as follows: art of not struggling (of accommodating oneself, of winning by making oneself everything to everyone); of ability to manage men; of action conforming to that of heaven. All these formulae designate the same thing. They show the greatness of the ancients. up

eat the foe You only win if you don't strive And gain if you do not oppose This is the certain victory Simplicity bestows

The best user of men acts as though he were their inferior and puts himself below them by the virtue of not-competing. This is called the ability or capacity to use men, or matching heaven, or being suited to the highest found principle, [maybe of old]

One who is skilful in using men puts himself below them. This is called the virtue of non-competing. This is called the strength to use men. This is called matching Heaven, the highest principle of old. up

Chapter 69

Sayings on Military Operations There are sayings on the use of arms: "Let us not be aggressors, but defend." "Let us not advance an inch, but retreat a foot." This is called carrying out no action, shaking no arm, facing no enemy, wielding no weapon.	Rather be on the defensive than the offensive, rather retreat a step than advance an inch, are current principles of military art. It is worth more to yield than to triumph. Prevention (of war) through diplomacy is worth even more.	In conflict just be cautious And always on your guard Rather than advance an inch Instead retreat a yard In this way you go along An		The strategists say: "I dare not take the offensive but I take the defensive; I dare not advance an inch but I retreat a foot." This means: To march without formation, To stretch one's arm without showing it, To confront enemies without seeming to meet them, To hold weapons without seeming to have them.
No calamity is greater than underestimating opponents. If you underestimate opponents, you're close to losing your treasure. So when opposing armies clash, the compassionate are the ones who win. up		d make your gain without advancing You deal with the rival As your position is enhancing Remember that it's possible Your rival just may yield So don't advance on such a foe Let differences be healed		There is no greater disaster than to make light the enemy. Therefore when armies are mobilized and issues joined, The man who is sorry over the fact will win. up

Chapter 70

My Sayings Are Very Easy to Recognize My sayings are very easy to recognize, and very easy to apply. But no one in the world can recognize them, and no one can apply them.

What I (Lao Zi) teach is easy to understand and to practice, and yet the world neither understands or practices it. My precepts and procedures derive from a superior principle and procedure, the Principle and its Virtue.

Embarrassingly obvious And always near at hand It is this nothingness you see But never understand Th

My words are very easy to understand and very easy to put into practice. Yet no one understands them; no one puts them into practice. But some of my teaching could have nature as a source, and also there's a principle-ruled ancestry in some of my words.

My doctrines are easy to understand and very easy to practice, But none in the world can understand or practice them. My doctrines have a source (Nature); my deeds have a master (Tao).

Sayings have a source, events have a leader. It is only through ignorance that I am not known. Those who know me are rare; those who emulate me are noble. This is why sages dress plainly, and conceal what is precious. up

The world does not recognize the Principle which directs me, that is why it does not know me. Very few understand me. That makes my glory. It befalls me to be like the Sage who is unrecognized from amongst the common people because of his humble appearance, even though his interior is filled with jewels. up

ough truth within is ageless Very few will ever see My face is what I give to you The jewel within is me

Yes, [some of] my deeds have a lord; my deeds could have [right] dao as sovereign. Most men don't understand this, they're unable to understand me. Few people understand me, and on this my real value depends. I am highly valued, for few understand me. The wise man wears a coarse cloth on top and carries jade underneath his dress, within his bosom.

It is because people do not understand this that they do not understand me. Few people know me, and therefore I am highly valued. Therefore the sage wears a coarse cloth on top and carries jade within his bosom. up

Chapter 71

Knowing Unconsciously To know unconsciously is best. To presume to know what you don't is sick. Only by recognizing the sickness of sickness is it possible not to be sick.	Knowing all and believing that one knows nothing, is true knowledge (of a superior kind). Knowing nothing and believing that one knows everything, is the common evil of humans.	You cannot understand the truth Claim to know and show you're ill Just see that you are missing Tha	To know that you do not know is best. Who knows that he doesn't know is the highest. To know when one doesn't know is best. Who pretends to know what he doesn't know is sick-minded; To think one knows when one doesn't know is a sort of malady. Pretend to know when you don't know - that's a disease.	To know that you do not know is the best. To pretend to know when you do not know is a disease.
The sages' freedom from ills was from recognizing the sickness of sickness, so they didn't suffer from sickness. up	Seeing this evil as an evil, keeps one away from it. The Sage is exempt from self-conceit, because he dreads it. This fear keeps him from it. up	t truth is bare and nil Unknowing is the final cure When knowledge takes its heavy toll Pure presence is totality And absence makes you whole	He who recognises this disease as a disease can also cure himself of it [and maybe not]. [One may eventually get free from a disease by recognising it for what it is.] Who recognises sick-mindedness as sick-mindedness can't be wholly sick-minded, after all. The wise man is hardly sick-minded if he recognises sick mind as sick and also cures some diseases. He's hardly a sick mind.	Only when one recognizes this disease as a disease can one be free from the disease. The sage is free from the disease. Because he recognizes this disease to be disease, he is free from it. up

Chapter 72

When the People
Are Not Awed by
Authority When
the people are
not awed by
authority, then
great authority is
attained. Their
homes are not
small to them,
their livelihood
not tiresome.

Those (who
expose
themselves to
danger through
curiosity, love of
gain, or ambition)
should be afraid
when they are not
afraid. For they are
lost. Do not
consider your
place of birth too
restricting, do not
become
dissatisfied with
the condition in
which you were
born. (Stay what
you are and where
you are. The effort
to seek for better
could perhaps
cause you to lose
you way).

When the sense
of wonder goes
Disaster is not
far behind Don't
intrude in
people's lives
And they won'

When the people
do not fear what
is dreadful, Then
what is greatly
dreadful will fall
upon them. Do
not reduce the
living space of
their dwellings.
Do no oppress
their lives.

Just because
they do not tire of
it, it is not
tiresome to them.
Therefore sages
know themselves
but do not see
themselves.
They take care of
themselves but
do not exalt
themselves. So
they take one
and leave the
other. up

One does not
become
dissatisfied, if one
does not wish to
become so.
(Dissatisfaction is
always voluntary,
coming from
preparing one's
situation with
another, and
having preference
for the other). The
Sage knows his
worth but does not
show it, (he does
not feel the need
to show it off). He
respects himself
but does not try to
be esteemed. He
discerns, adopting
this, and rejecting
that (after the light
of his wisdom). up

t think you are
unkind The seer
sees both this
and that But
doesn't ask for
praise Finding
this immensity
With just a
simple inward
gaze

It is because you
do not oppress
them that they
are not
oppressed.
Therefore the
sage knows
himself but does
not show himself.
He loves himself
but does not
exalt himself.
Therefore he
rejects the one
but accepts the
other. up

Chapter 73

Boldness in Daring Means Killing Boldness in daring means killing; boldness in not daring means life. These two may help and may harm. Who knows the reason for what heaven dislikes? This is why even sages find it hard for them.		The way is very easy Its purposes prevail When all is done in silence Intention		He who is brave in daring will be killed. He who is brave in not daring will live. Of these two, one is advantageous and one is harmful. Who knows why Heaven dislikes what it dislikes? Even the sage considers it a difficult question.
The Way of heaven wins well without contest, responds well without speech, comes of itself uncalled, relaxed yet very resourceful. The net of heaven is vast; the holes are large but don't let slip. up	For the way of heaven (its constant conduct), is not to intervene positively. It wins without fighting. It makes things obey without giving orders. It makes them come without calling them. It brings everything to its conclusion whilst having the appearance of letting everything drag. The heavenly net catches all. Its mesh is wide, but no one escapes it. up	cannot fail Its net is vast and over all With meshes large and wide Yet it loses nothing Holds everything inside		The Way of Heaven does not compete, and yet is skillfully achieves victory. It does not speak, and yet it skillfully responds to things. It comes to you without your invitation. It is not anxious about things and yet it plans well. Heaven's net is indeed vast. Though its meshes are wide, it misses nothing. up

Chapter 74

If People Usually Don't Fear Death
If people usually don't fear death, how can death be used to scare them? If people are made to fear death, and you can catch and kill them when they act oddly, who would dare?

If the people do not fear death, what is the good of trying to control them by the threat of death? If they fear death, then only capture and execute those who cause disorder, turning the others away from doing likewise. (The legalists who are lavish with the death penalty and believe it will sort everything out, are therefore wrong).

You truly are what isn't born
You need not be afraid to die Just live your life and know that you Will

The people are not afraid of death. Why, then, threaten them with death? Suppose the people are always afraid of death and we can seize those who are vicious and kill them, Who would dare to do so?

There are always executioners. And to kill in place of an executioner is taking the place of a master carver. Those who take the place of a master carver rarely avoid cutting their hands. up

The servant of death (heaven), kills, (let him do it. Let us not do his work. He alone is capable of it). The man who wants to kill may end up like those who play with the carpenter's tools, and often lose a finger in their play. up

never lose the inner eye You can't control what is to be In using tools you don't command Unlike the master carpenter You're bound to cut your hand

To undertake executions for the master executioner is like hewing wood for him. It rarely happens you escape injuring your own hands. Now, often it happens as well that the executioner is killed - And to take the place of the executioner is in part like handling the hatchet for the master carpenter. He who handles the hatchet for the master carpenter seldom escapes injury to his hands.

There is always the master executioner (Heaven) who kills. To undertake executions for the master executioner is like hewing wood for the master carpenter. Whoever undertakes hewing wood for the master carpenter rarely escapes injuring his own hands. up

Chapter 75

People's Starvation When people are starving, it is because their governments take too much, causing them to starve. When people are hard to control, it is because of the contrivances of their governments, which make them hard to control.	If the people are hungry, it is because the prince eats up excessive sums of money (which he extorts from them). If the people are restive, it is because the prince does too much, (indisposes them by his innovations).	The people starve when taxes take The bulk of what they earn When leaders interfere too much They get rebellion in re	People are hungry because rulers eat too much income, too much tax-grain. Therefore they starve, but also because of bad interference from those above. Some turn hard to rule as their rulers do too many things. That's why they're hard to keep in order. If so, the people are not very afraid of death, as they're anxious to make a living.	The people starve because the ruler eats too much tax-grain. Therefore they starve. They are difficult to rule because their ruler does too many things. Therefore they are difficult to rule.
When people slight death, it is because of the earnestness with which they seek life; that makes them slight death. Only those who do not contrive to live are wise in valuing life. up	If the people expose themselves lightly to death (in hazardous enterprises), it is because he loves life too much, (love of well-being, of pleasure, of fame). He who does nothing in order to live, is wiser than he who harms himself in order to live. up	turn The people do not fear to die If leaders rob them of their lives But taking no more than you need You see that everybody thrives	That's why they take death lightly in such cases. So: Those who interfere not with their living that are wise in exalting life. Maybe he who seeks only little after life can excel in making life valuable. But all that have hearts set only little on life could be superior to those who set store by life.	The people take death lightly because their ruler strives for life too vigorously. Therefore they take death lightly. It is only those who do not seek after life that excel in making life valuable. up

Chapter 76

When People
Are Born When
people are born
they are supple,
and when they
die they are stiff.
When trees are
born they are
tender, and when
they die they are
brittle. Stiffness
is thus a
companion of
death, flexibility a
companion of
life.

When a man is
born he is supple
and weak (but full
of life); he
becomes strong
and powerful, and
then he dies. It is
the same for
plants, delicate
(herbaceous) at
first, then
becoming woody
at the time of their
death.

We're soft and
supple when
we're born Hard
and rigid when
we die Living
plants are pliable
Deadwood is
brittle a

When man is born,
he is tender and
weak. In death he
becomes stiff and
hard. All things,
the grass as well
as trees, are
supple and soft
while alive. When
dead they become
brittle and dried.
So hardness and
stiffness very often
accompany death,
the soft and gentle
could be
companions of life.

When man is
born, he is
tender and weak.
At death he is
stiff and hard. All
things, the grass
as well as the
trees, are tender
and supple while
alive. When
dead, they are
withered and
dried. Therefore
the stiff and the
hard are
companions of
death.

So when an
army is strong, it
does not prevail.
When a tree is
strong, it is cut
for use. So the
stiff and strong
are below, the
supple and
yielding on top.
up

He who is strong
and powerful is
marked for death;
he who is weak
and flexible is
marked for life.
The great army will
be defeated. The
great tree will be
cut down.
Everything that is
strong and great is
in a poorer
condition. The
advantage is
always with the
supple and the
weak. up

nd dry This way
life befriends the
weak But death
draws near the
strong The hard
and stiff are
bound to break
The supple
bends and goes
along

The headstrong
army will lose in
battle. They say
"the weapon that's
too hard will be
broken, the tree
that has the
hardest wood will
be cut down". Yes,
a hard tree will be
cut down. So the
hard and mighty
eventually should
be cast down; and
the soft and weak
may be set on
high.

The tender and
the weak are
companions of
life. Therefore, if
the army is
strong, it will not
win. If a tree is
stiff, it will break.
The strong and
the great are
inferior, while the
tender and the
weak are
superior. up

Chapter 77

The Way of Heaven The Way of heaven is like drawing a bow: the high is lowered, the low is raised; excess is reduced, need is fulfilled.		Nature's way of doing is like the bending of a bow For pulling on a bow you see The low go high and the high go low Nature takes from those who have	Heaven's way is like the bending of a bow. When a bow is bent the top comes down and the bottom-end comes up. So too could heaven take away from those who have too much, and give to those that have not enough. Take away from those that have too much and give to those that have not enough. But this is far from man's way. He takes away from those that have not enough to offer those who already have too much.	Heaven's Way is indeed like the bending of a bow. When (the string) is high, bring it down. When it is low, raise it up. When it is excessive, reduce it. When it is insufficient, supplement it. The Way of Heaven reduces whatever is excessive and supplements whatever is insufficient. The way of man is different.
The Way of heaven reduces excess and fills need, but the way of humans is not so: they strip the needy to serve those who have too much. up	Any superfluity ought to come back to the empire (to the people), but only he who possesses the Principle is capable of that. The Sage conforms himself to the Principle. He influences without attributing the result to himself. He accomplishes without appropriating his work to himself. He does not claim the title of the Sage, (but keeps himself in voluntary obscurity). up	And gives to those who lack When nature takes from human beings They fight to get it back But if you see you have it all You're not afraid to give away Expecting nothing in return It all comes back with no delay	The man of dao can fool enough and spare, and next give to the whole world. So the wise man acts, but doesn't possess, accomplishes but lays claim to no credit. If he accomplishes a task, achieves an aim, he doesn't wish to reveal himself as better than others. So he seems to claim no credit. He seems to have no wish to appear superior, no desire to display excellence.	It reduces the insufficient to offer to the excessive. Who is able to have excess to offer to the world? Only the man of Tao. Therefore the sage acts, but does not rely on his own ability. He accomplishes his task, but does not claim credit for it. He has no desire to display his excellence. up

Chapter 78

The Most Flexible Thing in the World
Nothing in the world is more flexible and yielding than water. Yet when it attacks the firm and the strong, none can withstand it, because they have no way to change it. So the flexible overcome the adamant, the yielding overcome the forceful.

In this world there is nothing more supple and weak than water; and yet no one, however strong and powerful he may be, can resist its action (corrosion, wear, wave action); and no being can do without it (for drinking, growth, etc.). Is it clear enough that weakness is worth more than strength, that suppleness can overcome rigidity?

Water is so very soft It overcomes because it yields
By wearing down the hardest rock
It shows what power weakness wields
The weak can overcome the strong

There's hardly anything more yielding than [gas, air, and] water, but almost none is better in attacking the resistant and hard, There are few substitutes for it. Thus the yielding may conquer the resistant and the soft the hard. This was utilised by none I knew.

There is nothing softer and weaker than water, And yet there is nothing better for attacking hard and strong things. For this reason there is no substitute for it. All the world knows that the weak overcomes the strong and the soft overcomes the hard.

Everyone knows this, but no one can do it. This is why sages say those who can take on the disgrace of nations are leaders of lands; those who can take on the misfortune of nations are rulers of the world. True sayings seem paradoxical. up

- Everyone agrees with this; but no one acts according to it. The Sages have said: "He who rejects neither moral filth nor political evil is capable of becoming the chief of a territory or the sovereign of the empire." (He who is supple enough to accommodate himself to all that; and not a rigid and systematic person). These words are quite true, even though they offend many. up

The soft can overcome the hard
Everybody knows it's true
So hold the low in high regard
The seer sees serenity
Where others see affliction
The seer sees the inner truth
Where others only see a fiction

Wise sayings, "Only he who has accepted the dirt of a country can be lord of its soil-shrines: can become heaven-accepted there. Who bears evils of the country can become a king. Who takes into himself the calumny of the world serves to preserve the state." Straight words seem crooked.

But none can practice it. Therefore the sage says: He who suffers disgrace for his country Is called the lord of the land. He who takes upon himself the country's misfortunes Becomes the king of the empire. Straight words seem to be their opposite. up

Chapter 79

Harmonize Bitter Enemies When you harmonize bitter enemies, yet resentment is sure to linger, how can this be called good? Therefore sages keep their faith and do not pressure others.	When the principle of a dispute has been settled (some accessory grievances) always remain, and things do not return to the state they were in before, (bruises remain). (Therefore the Sage never questions it, despite his right). Keeping his half of the agreement, he does not exact the execution (of what is written).	There's little good in making peace If resentment lingers You'll never see an end to blame If everyone is pointi	To allay the main discontent, but in a way that begets further discontents, can hardly be top successful. And to patch up great hatred is sure to leave some hatred behind; how can this be regarded as satisfactory? So the wise man keeps the obligation of a contract and refrains from blaming the other party.	To patch up great hatred is surely to leave some hatred behind. How can this be regarded as good? Therefore the sage keeps the left-hand portion (obligation) of a contract And does not blame the other party.
So the virtuous see to their promises, while the virtueless look after precedents. The Way of heaven is impersonal; it is always with good people. up	He who knows how to conduct himself after the Virtue of the Principle, lets his written agreements sleep. He who does not know how to conduct himself thus, exacts his due. Heaven is impartial. (If it were capable of some partiality), it would give advantage to good people, (those who act as in C. It would overwhelm them, because they ask for nothing). up	ng fingers It's better to be pointing At the peaceful and creative place Where you see naught but emptiness And others say they see your face	He stays where he is and does not go round making claims on people. Therefore good people attend to their obligations, while those without virtue attend to other people's mistakes. The way of heaven is impartial. It's always with the good man, without distinction of persons, to keep the good firmly supplied."	Virtuous people attend to their left-hand portions, While those without virtue attend to other people's mistakes. "The Way of Heaven has not favourites. It is always with the good man." up

Chapter 80

A Small State Has Few People A small state has few people. It has the people keep arms but not use them. It has them regard death gravely and not go on distant campaigns. Even if they have vehicles, they have nowhere to drive them. Even if they have weapons, they have nowhere to use them.

If I were king of a little state, of a little people, I would take care to use (put in charge) the few dozen capable men that this state would contain. I would prevent my subjects from traveling, by making them fear possible accidental death so much that they would not dare climb into a boat or carriage. I would prohibit all use of weapons.

If a land is small and the people few And the rulers recognize what's needed The simple ways of courtesy Are happily and gladly heeded For people need so little To live their lives aright Are food and home and clothing Not enough for pure delight?

Let there be a small country with few people. Let there be ten times and a hundred times as many utensils. But let them not be used. Let the people value their lives highly and not migrate far. Even if there are ships and carriages, none will ride in them. Even if there are arrows and weapons, none will display them.

It has the people go back to simple techniques, relish their food, like their clothes, be comfortable in their ways, and enjoy their work. Neighboring states may be so close they can hear each other's dogs and roosters, but they make it so that the people have never gone back and forth. up

Though nearby lands are close enough To hear their roosters crow The people will be so content That not a one will want to go

Let the people again knot cords and use them (in place of writing). Let them relish their food, beautify their clothing, be content with their homes, and delight in their customs. Though neighbouring communities overlook one another and the crowing of cocks and the barking of dogs can be heard, Yet the people there may grow old and die without ever visiting one another. up

Chapter 81

True Words Are Not Beautiful True words are not beautiful, beautiful words are not true. The good are not argumentative, the argumentative are not good. Knowers do not generalize, generalists do not know.	(I have finished. Perhaps you may find my discourse lacks something, is not very subtle, and is scarcely wise). This is because native frankness does not dress itself up, natural directness avoids quibbling, common sense can dispense with artificial erudition. The Sage does not hoard, but gives.	Truth need not be eloquent And eloquence may not be true There is no need to argue When truth is shining through Those who see may not be learned The learned may not see To see you merely need to look In pure simplicity The seer doesn't have to hoard And does not fear to lose The more you give, the more you have So why should you refuse?		True words are not beautiful; Beautiful words are not true. A good man does not argue; He who argues is not a good man. A wise man has no extensive knowledge; He who has extensive knowledge is not a wise man.
Sages do not accumulate anything but give everything to others, having more the more they give. The Way of heaven helps and does not harm. The Way for humans is to act without contention.	The more he does for men, the more he can do; the more he gives them, the more he has. Heaven does good to all, doing no evil to anyone. The Sage imitates it, acting for the good of all, and opposing himself to no one.	Why not give it all away? For emptiness brings benefit And as the seers always say The more you give, the more you get	The wise man has no need to hoard for himself. He lives for other people, seemingly, and grows richer himself if the more he uses for others, the more he has for himself - He gives to other people to get greater abundance. Heaven's way is to sharpen and bless, all free from harm of cutting, And the wise man's way is to act and accomplish without contending or striving.	The sage does not accumulate for himself. The more he uses for others, the more he possesses of his own. The Way of Heaven is to benefit others and not to injure. The Way of the sage is to act but not to compete.